

9998

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For my Dad, Lawrence Ligad.

FADE IN:

PROLOGUE

INT. GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM - NIGHT - YEAR 8122

A CHILD'S HAND folds red paper—one half over the other. A crease becomes a star.

FOUR NOTES sound against hospital glass.

Before the fourth can fade, a FIFTH answers from somewhere without air.

The GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM resolves around the sound—a descending circle carved into black stone. Thousands of faces vanish into the tiers below.

At its center, **DR. ELI MANA**, 38, stands inside a narrow column of white light.

Along the perimeter, sealed ministerial booths illuminate one by one. Documents are signed behind the glass before the discovery has even been announced.

DR. KIRA NIX, 35, watches from the edge of the stage, one hand closed around a palm-sized ceramic device. Four worn pressure surfaces cross its face.

Beside her, **DR. HARP VALE** grips a cracked medical tag engraved: **MARA VALE**.

DIRECTOR ROMAN records which ministers refuse to look afraid.

ELI

For as long as we have recorded
thought, humanity has asked what
survives us.

Behind him: a scan of a clinically dead brain. It's activity stops. Across the screen, a separate receiving lattice ignites with the same pattern.

ELI

We observed a signature persist after
cellular death and appear inside
another living mind.

Kira's research note materializes beneath his words, visible only in the stage glass:

PATTERN PERSISTENCE IS NOT IDENTITY.

ELI

Death ends a body. It may not end the
pattern.

A minister presses AUTHORIZE. Another acquires exclusive gestation access. A third opens a military channel.

Eli sees none of it. Or chooses the light in front of him.

ELI

Reincarnation is no longer a belief.
It is a measurable process.

Kira looks at him. The evidence did not say that. Grief did.

Across the chamber, the first compulsory-access order completes before the applause begins.

ELI

History is not behind us.

The CHILD'S HAND opens the paper star. The crease remains.

ELI

It is waiting.

The chamber erupts. Prayer. Fear. Calculation. The sealed booths remain silent. Eli searches for Kira. She is already looking at him. Between them: love, terror, and the first thing neither can take back.

Across the room, the first compulsory-access order populates before the applause ends. Harp sees it. Kira sees him see it.

**CORRUPTED AUTHENTICATED RECORD - INT. PROJECT REINCARNATION
/ EXECUTION LAB - LATER THAT NIGHT - YEAR 8122**

The applause becomes an EXPLOSION.

Fire folds a laboratory door inward. Cryogenic vapor races along the floor. An alarm keeps repeating one calm sentence: REINCARNATION-AI HUMAN TRIAL COMPLETE.

Dr. Eli Mana, crawls through the shattered glass, nearly unrecognizable from the man who stood before the forum. His lab coat is dark with blood. Neural ports have been burned into his skull. Around him R-AI maps a living mind into the light, extracts its continuity pattern, and routes toward a replacement body.

INSERT

REINCARNATION-AI (R-AI) — HUMAN TRIAL
0001 — VOLUNTEER: DR. ELI MANA
RESULT: SUCCESSFUL

INSERT

CLEMENCY EXCHANGE — PRISONER: DR. KIRA
NIX
CONDITION: SUCCESSFUL HUMAN TRIAL

Eli reaches a shattered cryo-pod.

Inside, Kira's body is frozen beneath a skin of white crystal. Her hand is raised against the glass. No vital signs. The state clock on her wrist has stopped at zero.

INSERT
CLEMENCY STATUS: DENIED

INSERT
EXECUTION COMPLETED — SEVEN MINUTES AGO

ELI
You promised.

A security screen clears. Dr. Harp Vale watches from the control room. His face is almost unreadable. Almost.

HARP (ON SCREEN)
They promised clemency if the trial worked.

ELI
It worked. OPEN THE POD!

Harp doesn't move.

HARP (ON SCREEN)
I know.

ELI
OPEN IT!

HARP (ON SCREEN)
She's been dead seven minutes.

A damaged speaker plays the final message recorded inside Kira's pod.

KIRA (RECORDING)
Eli—if they make return a prison,
break the bridge. Even if I'm inside
it. Don't preserve a cage because it
speaks with my voice.

ELI
I'll find you. Every time.

HARP (ON SCREEN)
No. You won't.

INSERT
ORIGIN MEMORY EXTRACTION — ACTIVE

Light pours from Eli's eyes into the first R-AI lattice. The system separates memory, instinct and identity into transfer-ready data. Kira's name vanishes from his language before her face leaves his heart. He keeps reaching after he forgets why.

A hidden process flickers beneath the extraction architecture.

INSERT
CONTINUITY TERMINATION – SOULSTREAM
SEVERANCE – PROTOCOL INCOMPLETE

Before recognition disappears, Eli presses his bloody hand against the pod.

Kira's recording distorts. Four broken tones repeat through the damaged speaker.

Eli answers with one final strike against the glass.

The record tears into white.

The first R-AI lattice divides into thousands of illuminated threads.

Years pass inside the machinery.

8122 – A dying woman opens her eyes inside another body.

8264 – Return becomes a licensed medical procedure.

8511 – The world's continuity archives merge into a single network.

9031 – The CHRONOCRACY absorbs the remaining governments. Their seals disappear beneath its own.

Birth chambers multiply beneath cities. Human lives become numbered state property.

Millions of numbered lives race through the lattice.

9997 - Every thread goes dark.

Then the sequence fractures. The network returns-with something inside it the Chronocracy cannot identify.

SUPER: 1,876 YEARS AFTER ELI MANA'S EXTRACTION

ACT ONE – THE ANOMALY

INT. RETURN CHAMBER - NIGHT - YEAR 9998 – NINE MONTHS AGO

A state-grown adult body hangs upright inside black glass.

KERR, 30s, wakes with no childhood, no family, and no memory of entering the chamber. A stranger's face stares back from every curved reflection.

On his wrist:

KERR – ITERATION 9998. CONTINUITY RECOVERY: INCOMPLETE.
STATE BODY LICENSE: PROVISIONAL.

DR. IMANI VOSS, 40s, a systems engineer whose composure looks practiced rather than natural, watches from behind the glass. A tiny prayer pouch hangs inside her collar—the one private thing she permits the state to see.

Kerr studies his unfamiliar hands.

KERR

Where was I?

IMANI

You weren't anywhere we know how to measure.

KERR

How long?

Imani looks at the designation on his wrist.

IMANI

Almost two centuries.

Four diagnostic tones sound inside the chamber.

Kerr's hand answers with a fifth knock against the glass.

The chamber goes still.

Far beneath them, the fifth beat enters the buried continuity grid.

Across the foundations of Chronos City, thousands of sealed Return chambers ignite one after another—empty glass holding light for the dead.

Imani's console displays a message no living system should recognize:

ORIGIN LINE – ACKNOWLEDGED

Before she can touch it, the message erases itself. The distant chambers go dark.

KERR

What was that?

IMANI

A fault.

INT. KERR'S STATE APARTMENT - MORNING - YEAR 9998

SUPER: PRESENT DAY — 274 DAYS AFTER RETURN

Kerr wakes before the state alarm. The apartment is narrow but lived-in: a stubborn green plant, a chipped cup, hand-drawn corrections taped over an official transit map.

His wrist reads KERR — ITERATION 9998. DAY 274. PROVISIONAL CITIZENSHIP. MANDATORY IDENTITY REVIEW 27.

He burns one side of real bread. Four knocks travel through a heating pipe. KERR answers with a fifth before he realizes his hand has moved.

In the window's condensation, his fingertip has traced a woman's eye. He wipes it away.

NEIGHBOR (O.S.)

Review day?

KERR

Twenty-seven. They're running out of ways to disappoint themselves.

On his way out, KERR leaves a repaired navigation tile beside his neighbor's door. His Mapworks credential pulses with a cancellation: REPORT TO CONTINUITY STABILIZATION.

IMANI waits at the end of the corridor with two cups. She hands Kerr the one without sweetener. He takes it without asking. Nine months have made this a ritual.

IMANI

You ate?

KERR

The bread lost.

They walk toward the review chamber together.

INT. CONTINUITY REVIEW CHAMBER - DAY

Black glass without visible edges. KERR enters through the only door. Every reflection shows him a fraction too late. IMANI takes her place at the manual console.

IMANI

State your designation.

KERR

Kerr. Still.

IMANI

Iteration?

KERR

Nine-nine-nine-eight.

IMANI

Day?

KERR

Two hundred seventy-four. Are we celebrating at two seventy-five?

A sealed record appears beside his reflection: ORIGIN
SUBJECT – CLASSIFIED. ARCHIVED PATTERN CORRESPONDENCE: 91.7
PERCENT. ORIGIN AUTHORITY – UNCLAIMED.

KERR

Still no name.

IMANI

Harp requested a recognition review.

KERR

Nine months. Twenty-seven reviews.
What answer are they waiting for?

IMANI

Recognition. Whoever they think came back.

KERR

And if I recognize him?

IMANI

The state stops calling your origin provisional.

KERR

That sounds less like an answer than a transfer of ownership.

IMANI

It's both.

KERR

What happens if I never recognize
whatever it is that I need to
recognize?

CORE LINK

ORIGIN AUTHORITY REMAINS UNCLAIMED.

A crack appears across the glass, dividing the classified silhouette from KERR's reflection.

Beyond the observation wall, DIRECTOR ROMAN records the fracture. His face is not the face from 8122. The stillness is.

IMANI

That glass has held through wars and
riots. It hasn't cracked since the
Fracture.

KERR

Did I fail the test?

IMANI

No. That may be the problem.

KERR

Nine months ago, I arrived with a name
and a number. Everything after that, I
built.

IMANI

Then we start with what belongs to you.

INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - LATER

Kerr sits beneath projected civic history. IMANI works at a manual console connected by a sealed hardline to R-AI's Continuity Core beneath Chronos City. R-AI exists only there. Everywhere else, fixed terminals submit narrow requests and repeat its authorized results. The records occupy the wall; Kerr and Imani remain visible beneath them. Recorded voices carry a faint glass resonance. Live voices don't.

INSERT

ARCHIVAL RECORD — SOURCE: CHRONOCRACY

YEAR 8123. The last natural-born human dies. Licensed gestation replaces birth. Spontaneous, unlicensed memory recall is genetically suppressed before the next generation can inherit it.

INSERT

THE GREAT FORGETTING — PEACEFUL
TRANSITION COMPLETE

Kerr watches sleeping children beneath monitors that flag unlicensed neural recall.

YEAR 9785. R-AI scans inherited patterns and identifies 3,104,881 people statistically likely to rebel.

INSERT
THE SILENT UPRISING – ZERO CIVIC
CASUALTIES

YEAR 9997. A woman inside a state scanner linked to the central R-AI core opens twelve contradictory lives at once. The prediction system physically fractures.

INSERT
NULL-PATTERN SUBJECT – TWELFTH
RECORDED DEATH

For three seconds, the entire network fails. In those three seconds, an unassigned host in the Continuity Reserve awakens without a continuity pattern.

INSERT
UNINDEXED HOST V-16 – CLASSIFIED

KERR

Who is she?

IMANI

The record won't say.

Kerr's breath catches. His fingertips press four shallow dents into the arm of the chair. He looks back at the woman frozen inside the corrupted record.

Imani rolls a calibration tray between them. Three objects sit beneath white light: a cracked lens, a laboratory seal with its name burned away, and a battered analog sketchbook. The book came from the sealed origin archive. Its identifying marks have been removed. Equations survive on the first pages. The rest appear blank. Kerr touches the laboratory seal. Nothing. The cracked lens. Nothing.

His thumb catches on the sketchbook's cloth cover.

KERR

Take it.

Imani reaches for the book. He opens it to a blank page. Faint pressure grooves cross the paper—marks left by hands.

Kerr drags the Side of a graphite stick across the page, trying to expose the grooves. A woman's eyes emerge.

He stops.

His hand moves again. New lines cut across clean paper: a girl beneath Earth repeated around a black sun, each image marked with a different future.

KERR

That wasn't in the paper.

The ceiling camera tightens focus.

Imani drops a calibration slate over the page and tags the event INVOLUNTARY MOTOR ARTIFACT – INCONCLUSIVE.

Kerr looks at her. She has just lied for him.

Imani leaves the sketchbook beneath the slate, within his reach.

**INTERCUT - INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - UNASSIGNED BODY SECTOR
- NIGHT**

An unassigned sixteen-year-old host wakes among thousands of preserved bodies. Condensation and frost conceal her face. Before the monitoring lead can register consciousness, she tears it from her chest.

In the Stabilization Suite, the ceiling camera extracts the unknown girl's face from Kerr's drawing and searches the Continuity Reserve inventory.

INSERT

POSSIBLE BIOMETRIC
CORRESPONDENCE – HOST V-16

IDENTITY: UNASSIGNED

The system begins resolving V-16's location.

UNINDEXED HOST LOCATION
RESOLVING

Kerr sees the preserved bodies entering the search field. He drives his thumb into the origin port embedded beneath his wrist nine months ago.

IMANI

If you break that claim, the state
will classify you as hostile
continuity.

KERR

It's using me to find her.

He tears the port free. Blood crosses the classified silhouette. The location collapses one meter before reaching V-16.

INSERT

ORIGIN AUTHENTICATION –
CORRUPTED

Every door in Chronos City locks. His apartment access, Mapworks credential, and provisional citizenship vanish in

succession. Nine months of life become three red words:
HOSTILE CONTINUITY — REVOKED.

In the Continuity Reserve, the unidentified figure studies
five marks in the condensation beside her—four together,
one apart. Frost keeps her face unreadable.

Every clock in the suite blanks. A new number appears
across the glass.

CONTINUITY TERMINATION AUTHORIZED —
HARP VALE

ORIGIN-LAYER CONVERGENCE — 72:00:00

KERR

What did she wake up?

IMANI

A purge clock.

KERR

How long?

IMANI

Seventy-two hours.

KERR

Until what?

Imani looks toward the dark camera in the ceiling.

IMANI

Harp is moving every continuity
waiting for return into the origin
layer.

KERR

Why?

IMANI

The system saw V-16 and panicked. At
zero, he closes reincarnation
permanently.

KERR

What happens to the people waiting?

Imani doesn't answer.

KERR

Imani.

IMANI

He keeps whatever he can fit inside
one protected continuity.

KERR

His?

IMANI

Yours opens the door.

The purge clock begins to fall: 71:59:42.

The recorded voices cut out. The history projection vanishes, returning us fully to Kerr and Imani. Four symbols remain: a closed circle, a broken circle, a black square, and a gold spiral.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Memory-access protocol. Authenticated record. Unstable recall. Forbidden record. Pre-echo.

KERR

Which one tells me what actually happened?

IMANI

One tells you what an instrument captured. One tells you what a mind rebuilt. One tells you what someone hid. The pre-echo should have no cause at all.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Authenticated record selected.
Personal history. Year 8119.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - PERSONAL HISTORY - INT. FAMILY
APARTMENT - MORNING - YEAR 8119**

Ordinary sunlight. Kira burns toast. Eight-year-old SID MANA-NIX draws constellations on the ceiling with a toy projector. One front tooth is missing. She folds two pieces of red paper and locks them together into a star.

KIRA

You used two pieces.

SID

If one gets lost, the other still keeps the folds.

ELI

Paper doesn't remember.

SID

Then why's the crease still there?
Checkmate, paper.

Eli starts to answer, realizes he has been outmaneuvered by an eight-year-old.

SID

Four notes means, "Are you still there?"

Kira taps four notes on a glass. SID answers with a bright fifth.

KIRA

And that means?

SID

"I heard you."

ELI

That's not how information theory works.

SID

You came in from the other room, right? So it worked. You're welcome.

KIRA

Peer review is devastating at this age.

ELI

One subject, no control group. Brutal methodology.

SID

I control both of you. Tiny sample, huge power.

Eli laughs.

The record advances. Before R-AI, Eli's receiver is an assistive neural-audio translator built to translate SID's failing speech. Sid sits beneath handmade sensors while Kira tunes brain activity into sound. Eli writes the receiver. Harp installs a consent gate. Years later, the state will build Reincarnation-AI around this architecture.

HARP

It can't initiate contact, retain a response, or identify a speaker without permission.

SID

Good. What happens if I change my mind after I say yes?

HARP

Then it stops and deletes the session.

SID

Even if Dad says it's important?

HARP

Especially then.

ELI

You understand all that?

SID

I understand adults invent longer words for being scared. Uncle Harp invents rules.

HARP

Someone in this family should.

Kira presses the first RESONANCE KEY against the glass and touches its four ceramic surfaces. The prototype carries the notes through the bed frame. Sid's neural response returns as the FIFTH.

SID

It remembered me.

ELI

It translated a repeatable neural pattern. Remembering would imply an internal experience we haven't established.

SID

That is a scientist's way of agreeing and hoping nobody notices.

KIRA

She has you there.

Sid asks the prototype to delete the session. Harp activates the consent gate. The screen clears.

One impossible event remains: the FIFTH NOTE sounds a fraction of a second before Sid's brain produces it.

ELI

Prediction artifact. Weird one, but still...

KIRA

Or feedback from a system we don't understand yet.

ELI

The note arrived before the signal that should have produced it.

HARP

Write down what happened. The signal came early. We don't know why. That's enough mystery for one morning.

On the blank screen, four words appear without a prompt: I HEARD YOU BEFORE.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - YEAR 9998

Kerr returns with Sid's two-piece red paper star drawn in the sketchbook margin. He has drawn the interlocking crease without being shown it—and older pressure grooves beneath his fresh lines follow the same fold.

KERR

Sid.

IMANI

The girl's name was Sid. The other identities are sealed.

KERR

That was his memory, right?

IMANI

Feelings can survive a transfer. That doesn't make you the person who felt them first.

KERR

Real feeling.

IMANI

That distinction will save you pain if you remember it.

KERR

It'll cause pain either way.

The authenticated image destabilizes. Rain replaces the apartment sunlight.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Unstable recall detected. Source confidence: indeterminate.

UNSTABLE RECALL - INT. DR. ELARA'S OFFICE - DAY (8121)

Rain on old glass. No screens. Kerr experiences the scene through the sealed patient's eyes. DR. ELARA, 44, trauma psychologist, watches him turn Sid's red paper star. The patient's face glitches in reflection.

ELARA

You have explained quantum persistence for forty minutes.

ELI

You asked what I believe happens after death. I'm trying to answer carefully.

ELARA

Careful isn't the same as honest. What do you miss?

Eli looks at the star.

ELI

She'd try to hold in a laugh, but the gap in her teeth made it whistle. Then she'd laugh harder because I noticed.

ELI

I don't know how to believe something I can't measure.

ELARA

And grief is what happens when words aren't enough. There's nothing wrong with either.

ELI

If a signal persists, death may be a failure of reception. If I can improve the receiver—

ELARA

Then you may discover something extraordinary. But a response is not automatically your daughter coming home.

Elara writes three statements on paper.

INSERT

EVERY RETRIEVAL MAY ALTER A MEMORY.

INSERT

PATTERN PERSISTENCE IS NOT IDENTITY.

INSERT

BUT IT IS NOT NOTHING.

ELARA

A retrieved memory becomes unstable before the brain stores it again. Remembering is not opening a file. It's rebuilding a room while standing inside it.

ELI

Then no memory can be trusted?

ELARA

Trust is not certainty. You trust her even when you remember the same morning differently.

Elara takes the paper star from him, opens it, then gives it back unfolded.

ELARA

The danger is believing love makes every method permissible.

ELI

People can still feel connected to someone after they're gone. We understood that long before.

ELARA

We do. Grief researchers call it a continuing bond. Sometimes it helps the living keep living.

ELI

Which is this?

ELARA

Look at the star. You folded it until it tore. Say her name.

The office repeats. Rain reverses. The sealed patient disappears; present-day Kerr replaces him in the chair, holding the star. Elara's face becomes R-AI's civic mask, then Elara again.

KERR

Are you Elara or a reconstruction?

ELARA

That question belongs to you, not this memory.

KERR

Then why am I seeing this?

ELARA

I don't know. But you brought the same star.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - YEAR 9998

Kerr returns with the red star drawn across three sketchbook pages. Folded together, their disconnected margins form the same woman's eyes.

KERR

Was that authenticated?

IMANI

No. The system reconstructed Elara from the sealed patient's therapy records, recorded sessions and your present cognition.

KERR

So she never said those words.

IMANI

Some were in her notes. Some may have been hers. Some were yours. The retrieval system can't separate them

after capture, which is why Harp usually deletes the distinction before anyone asks.

KERR

Then why show me?

MEMORY CONSOLE

Unstable recall can reveal current meaning. It can't establish historical fact.

KERR

That explanation would have been useful before you put me in a room with a dead woman who knew what I was thinking.

MEMORY CONSOLE

The Chronocracy found the distinction politically inefficient.

IMANI

That means yes. She could have warned you.

The door opens. Harp heard the last sentence.

INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - NIGHT

HIGH REGENT HARP VALE enters alone. His twelfth body is elegant, controlled, and too young for the grief in his eyes. Twelve renewal dates shimmer beneath his wrist.

HARP

You always wake angry.

KERR

Were you always there when I woke?

HARP

For the important ones, yes. Sometimes you asked for water. Sometimes you tried to kill me before your legs worked. Once you apologized for not recognizing me.

KERR

Which one did you prefer?

HARP

The one who asked why.

KERR

Imani said you need my continuity to open something.

HARP

The Origin Gate.

KERR

And what do you need from me?

HARP

Recognition. Given freely and entered into the record.

KERR

You mean a name.

HARP

I mean your acknowledgment that the name belongs to you.

KERR

And if I don't give it to you?

HARP

The state will establish continuity without your cooperation.

KERR

So this review is paperwork.

HARP

It's an opportunity to settle the matter voluntarily.

Harp gestures. The purge clock expands across the wall.

HARP

When that clock reaches zero, every mind awaiting Return will be erased. My continuity will be protected.

KERR

Protected where?

HARP

Inside a single address the carrier cannot divide or retrieve.

KERR

You're not saving anyone. You're negotiating to be the last person left.

For the first time, Harp looks his age.

Harp studies Kerr's sketchbook. Separate pages overlap: the woman's eyes, four notes and fragments of corridor geometry.

HARP

Every version of you left something in that book. Scribbles. Nonsense. This time the drawings are converging. She

has twelve recorded deaths and hundreds of unrecorded bodies. The central prediction model can't reduce her lives to one outcome. That is what Null means. Not empty.

INT. SERVICE CORRIDOR - MINUTES LATER

Imani unlocks Kerr's room with an analog override braided into the cord of her prayer pouch. The panel requests authorization. She enters the same SENSOR NOISE code she used to delay Kerr's report, turning her earlier lie into an open breach. A corridor camera pivots from Imani to Kerr. Its facial lock climbs toward one hundred percent; Kerr's wrist flashes ORIGIN CLAIMANT, then DEFECTIVE RETURN. **COMMANDER SATO**, 50s, a veteran Enforcer whose loyalty implant has outlived three bodies, waits beneath it with a weapon and a battered mechanical watch.

KERR

And you are?

SATO

At the moment, I'm the man pointing the weapon away from you. Take the temporary comfort.

Sato sees DEFECTIVE RETURN. His thumb presses the watch crown as if stopping an old reflex. Then he shoots the corridor camera before facial lock completes. The red upload light dies. A state notice flashes through the smoke: FEED LOST – NEAREST ENFORCER NEURAL RELAY IN 00:00:40. The countdown binds the broken camera to Sato's loyalty implant.

SATO

You have forty seconds before my loyalty implant repairs the disloyal thought I just had and gives me a convincing reason to shoot the two of you.

IMANI

I bought us the door. Why are you opening it now?

SATO

The last person I brought through this corridor was my daughter. The state said there wasn't enough of her left to count. I believed them.

SATO

Then the state prediction showed me tomorrow. Every train arrived on time.

Every street was clean. Nobody was alive enough to be late.

IMANI

If we leave this room, where are you going?

KERR

The woman in the record. I need to know why Harp buried her—and I need one choice in this body to actually be mine.

IMANI

That is not a route, but it is finally a direction.

They run.

INT. TRANSIT SPINE - NIGHT

Enforcers close from both ends. The corridor predicts their movement in red light before they make it.

IMANI

Don't decide until you move.

KERR

That is impossible. Moving is a decision.

IMANI

Not if panic gets there first.

Kerr flips open the sketchbook. A line drawn in the chamber matches the corridor's red prediction path. He steps left, remembers dying left, spins right. A drone fires where his intention had been.

SATO

Fall now. You can have a moral objection during transit.

He opens an emergency hatch. They plunge.

EXT. CHRONOS CITY - NIGHT

They emerge onto a transit spine suspended above CHRONOS CITY.

The city isn't crowded. However, it's enormous enough to make crowds disappear. Black towers rise like geological formations. Transit lines cut through them with surgical precision. The silence is engineered.

Far above: private gardens and unoccupied rooms. Far below: body-renewal queues packed beneath leaking conduits.

Preservation chambers travel overhead in transparent freight tubes.

Citizens cross a plaza large enough for an army. Their former lives appear only when the state recognizes them. Expiration dates burn beneath their wrists like social rank.

A CHILD steps outside her assigned lane. The paving stone lights red. Her mother returns her to the line before an Enforcer turns around.

Across the haze above every tower, the seventy-two-hour purge countdown occupies the sky.

A civic lesson repeats: LIFE ALLOCATION. BODY TERM CLAIMANT. MEMORY PROVEN. RETURN PRESERVATION.

KERR

The Chronocracy?

IMANI

It picks your body, edits your memories, schedules your death.

KERR

Who chose Harp?

SATO

The first generation.

Every camera turns toward Kerr. A municipal speaker wakes. Its vocabulary is limited to enforcement commands.

CIVIC SECURITY

RETURN TO CARE, ORIGIN CLAIMANT.

KERR

KERR.

CIVIC SECURITY

SELF-DESIGNATION CORRECTION REGISTERED.

KERR

Can R-AI hear me?

CIVIC SECURITY

REPORT TO CARE.

KERR

That was not an answer.

IMANI

Because R-AI isn't in the speaker. It is buried beneath the city. This terminal can only read the orders it was given.

For less than a frame, an encrypted audit header flickers beneath the civic feed. The terminal can't open it. Kerr

sees only the Core's refusal code because his return is still out of calibration.

INSERT
CENTRAL R-AI AUDIT LOG 07 – REMOTE
REQUEST DENIED

INSERT
CORE ITERATION 0043 – ANOMALOUS MEMORY
RESILIENCE

INSERT
RECOMMENDATION: OBSERVE. Don't
INTERVENE.

INSERT
ADDENDUM: CONTRADICTION REGISTERED.

INSERT
AUDIT REVIEW REQUIRED. DISCLOSURE
PROHIBITED.

Imani sees the contradictory orders before the municipal terminal restores its blank enforcement screen.

For one frame, every civic screen shows the silhouette of a girl drawing Earth repeated around a black sun, each image marked with a different future.

A FIFTH NOTE escapes every municipal speaker before the next security command arrives. A dark spiral turns beneath Kerr's reflection. The city audio cuts out.

CIVIC SECURITY
UNINDEXED HOST SEARCH ACTIVE.

The cameras turn away.

EXT. TEMPLE OF RETURN - NIGHT

They descend into a temple filled with shallow black water. Families wait on isolated platforms beneath queue numbers. Ministers pray. Clerks calculate. No one acknowledges the difference.

A WOMAN holds her dying husband on one platform. A young replacement body sleeps on another, fifty meters away. The state gives the family thirty seconds to prove sufficient continuity.

WOMAN
Will he remember me?

MINISTER
If the bond served continuity.

WOMAN
I asked whether he'll know my face.

The replacement body's eyes open. Across the water, the husband's wrist advances from twelve minutes to three seconds. His wife sees both bodies and can reach neither.

At zero, his first body falls into the water. The replacement sits up before the splash reaches the platform.

The clerk removes the dead man's number from the queue. The next family is called.

The WOMAN understands: the date was never a prediction. It was an appointment.

MINISTER

He has entered lawful return.

INT. ANALOG ZONE - NIGHT

The corridor narrows until the city can no longer stand upright around them. Electric light gives way to candles. Low ceilings sweat. Pipes cross walls repaired in five different centuries. Mechanical watches disagree. Somewhere, someone laughs too loudly. For the first time, no system hum tells them what the room expects.

A MASKED WOMAN steps from the candlelight. A cracked ceramic RESONANCE KEY rests in her palm, small enough to disappear. Kerr's sketchbook falls open. The eyes he drew in the chamber stare back from the page—and from above her mask.

KERR

I've been drawing your eyes.

MASKED WOMAN

You've been drawing someone. That's not the same as meeting me.

MASKED WOMAN

First tell me why your book knows this place.

KERR

I don't know. Every time I remember something, the drawings get less wrong.

She takes the sketchbook without touching him.

She flips past the sealed equations, Sid's folded star and the woman's eyes. Across several pages, stray lines join into a route through the Analog Zone.

KERR

Those lines were there before I left the chamber.

MASKED WOMAN

And now they map my home. Cute. Also terrifying.

She keeps her mask on and leads them deeper. At every junction, the sketchbook route matches the architecture a moment before Kerr sees it.

MASKED WOMAN

Follow me.

KERR

What if it brought me to you?

MASKED WOMAN

Then it made a mistake.

KERR

You recognized me.

MASKED WOMAN

I recognized something.

KERR

What?

Kerr tries not to smile. The left corner of his mouth lifts.

The Masked Woman goes still.

MASKED WOMAN

That.

KERR

My mouth?

MASKED WOMAN

You always did that when you knew someone was lying.

KERR

How many times have you seen me?

At the final turn, the newest sketch aligns with the room around them.

The Masked Woman studies the completed portrait, then removes her mask. It's the face Kerr's hand has been approaching page by page.

KIRA

My name is Kira.

KERR

The woman from the Fracture?

KIRA

The body from the Fracture.

KERR

I watched you die.

KIRA

Then you saw what happened.

KERR

How are you standing here?

KIRA

The network went down before R-AI came back online. An old consent safeguard diverted my continuity into an unlicensed unassigned host.

KERR

Is it really you?

KIRA

I don't know. Some days I remember dying. Other days it feels like I watched it happen to someone else.

KERR

Why keep the name?

KIRA

Because when I woke up, it was the first thing that felt like mine.

KERR

Does Harp know?

KIRA

Harp knows every Kira he recorded.

She steps closer, allowing him to see the unfamiliar details of her face.

KIRA

He hasn't met this one. And I want out of this loop.

KERR

The forced Returns—or all of it?

KIRA

All of it. If the soulstream is the only place Harp can't follow, that's where I want to go.

KIRA

I've died twelve times. Every time I wake up, somebody is waiting to tell me what I owe them. I want that to stop.

KERR

And everyone else's soul?

Kira can't answer without hearing how close her rage has come.

KIRA

And that's where I stop. I don't get to make that call for everyone.

INT. ANALOG ZONE - LIVING QUARTERS - NIGHT

Kira leads the group through rooms carved beneath the city. People repair clocks, teach children to write by hand and play instruments whose mistakes aren't corrected.

A mural lists the rights forbidden above: THE RIGHT TO FORGET. THE RIGHT TO REFUSE RETURN. THE RIGHT TO CHANGE WITHOUT EXPLANATION.

KERR

How many people live here?

KIRA

Six hundred and twelve tonight.
Tomorrow, who knows? People leave when they want. Harp can't stand that.

A return alarm sounds inside a side room. Kira enters. Kerr follows.

LENA, 30s, wakes in an illegal body. DANE, 60s, waits beside her holding a wedding photograph. Lena studies him without recognition.

DANE

You came back.

LENA

Who are you?

Dane reaches for her. Kira catches his wrist before contact.

KIRA

Ask.

DANE

She's my wife.

KIRA

She was. This woman just woke up. Ask before you put forty-three years on her.

Dane's hope turns defensive.

DANE

We had forty-three years.

LENA

Sorry. I can tell I'm hurting you, and I don't even know what I did.

DANE

You didn't do anything. You're disoriented. It'll come back when the transfer settles.

KIRA

Dane. Take your hand off her.

Kerr sees the cruelty and mercy of the sentence.

Dane lowers his hand.

DANE

My name is Dane. I knew someone who looked like you before she died.

LENA

Did you love her?

DANE

Very much. We were terrible before breakfast.

LENA

Was she kind?

DANE

Not reliably. She tried. That was one of the things I loved.

A small smile reaches Lena without memory.

DANE

May I sit here?

LENA

Yes.

He sits at a distance and turns the wedding photograph face down.

LENA

You can leave it up.

DANE

Only if you ask. I've already brought enough into your first morning.

Kira exits. Kerr follows her into the corridor.

KERR

How often does this happen?

KIRA

Enough that the state gave her seventy-two hours to remember him.

KERR

And if she doesn't?

KIRA

They take her body.

KERR

Dane knew that?

KIRA

He helped us steal it.

They look back. Dane remains where Lena left him. He does not follow her.

KERR

What happens now?

KIRA

He waits.

KERR

Is that what you're doing with me?

KIRA

I'm trying.

KERR

That isn't an answer.

KIRA

It's the one I have.

They pass a classroom. Children draw people and places absent from every licensed record.

IMANI watches a girl erase a woman from her drawing, then put her back.

IMANI

My mother refused another body.

KERR

You understood?

IMANI

No. I called her selfish.

KERR

Were you wrong?

IMANI

I wanted her alive. At the time, that felt like the same thing.

An Analog musician loses the melody, curses under his breath and starts again.

INT. ANALOG SAFEHOUSE - LATER

A cramped kitchen assembled from scavenged centuries.

Kira burns toast over a heating coil. Kerr reaches across her and kills the heat before the alarm sounds.

KIRA

You always did that.

KERR

Burn the toast?

KIRA

Notice two seconds too late.

KERR

That sounds more believable.

KIRA

You don't know what sounds like you yet.

The remark lands harder than she intended.

On the wall: Kira's folded half of Sid's red paper star, a map beneath the capital and four memory symbols.

Kerr points to the gold spiral.

KERR

What's that one?

KIRA

A pre-echo. A memory recorded before the event that caused it.

KERR

The girl beneath the black sun.

Kira turns to him.

KIRA

Where did you hear that?

KERR

I didn't.

He opens the sketchbook. The repeated drawing stares up at them.

KERR

I've been drawing her since I woke up.

Kira takes the book. For the first time, Kerr sees her genuinely frightened.

KERR

Is she real?

KIRA

There's one record like this. We never found the person in it.

KERR

But Harp tried.

KIRA

He's still trying.

She opens the map. A route descends beneath the capital toward the Continuity Core.

KIRA

Harp can read everything R-AI kept. He still can't open the Origin Core.

KERR

Why not?

KIRA

It needs Eli's pattern in a living body.

Kerr looks at the route ending beneath the city.

KERR

Me.

KIRA

That's what Harp needs the system to believe.

KERR

What do you believe?

KIRA

If Harp knew, he wouldn't be hunting you.

She marks one symbol: ORIGIN. Beneath it, the state has written: LIVING CLAIMANT – UNCONFIRMED.

IMANI

V-16.

KIRA

The unassigned host from the Fracture. If she's alive, Harp doesn't know what she is either.

KERR

You want to use her against him.

KIRA

I want to reach her first. Then she decides.

Kira draws a route from the Continuity Reserve to R-AI's Origin Core, then circles the falling purge clock.

KIRA

We get V-16 out. If she comes with us, Kerr opens the Core and we find out what happened during the Fracture.

KERR

And if we fail?

IMANI

Everyone waiting to return is erased.
Harp is all that remains.

The route is simple. Nothing after the rescue is.

INT. ANALOG SAFEHOUSE - NIGHT

Kerr touches Kira's half of the red paper star. Grief reaches him without a name or image attached.

KERR

Who was he?

KIRA

Someone I loved. I'm not giving you
his name before you see what he did.

KERR

Harp thinks he is inside me.

KIRA

Harp needs your body to make an old
record count. That doesn't mean he
knows you.

KERR

Then we find it before he names me for
it.

KIRA

What if it feels like yours?

KERR

Then I still decide what I do with it.

Kira places the resonance key in his
palm and closes his fingers around it.
She does not give him her hand.

Every mechanical clock in the safe-house stops at once. The
candle flames lean toward the walls as the state grid finds
the room.

CIVIC SECURITY (V.O.)

Analog Zone coordinates resolved.
Sanctuary purge authorized.

Stone shutters slam down. Above them, Enforcer charges
strike the street.

SATO

Well. Decision made. Safe route's gone.

Kira pulls an emergency lever. The floor drops beneath
Kerr, Kira, Imani and Sato, spilling them into a

maintenance trench as the safe-house folds into fire overhead.

The shaft seals behind them. There is no way back to the life Kerr spent nine months building.

ACT TWO – THE CLAIM

INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - NIGHT

A refrigerated vault disappears into darkness. Thousands of state-grown bodies stand inside vertical preservation chambers, catalogued by age, health and projected civic use. The stillness is administrative, not peaceful.

KERR, KIRA, IMANI and SATO move through a maintenance trench beneath the sector. The citywide purge clock reads 61:36:09.

IMANI

Every chamber reports directly to the Continuity Core. If the hardline reconnects, Harp sees us.

KERR

How long do we have?

IMANI

I cut the local relay. It could stay down for a minute. It could be back already.

Kira presses the resonance key to a coolant pipe and touches its four worn surfaces. The notes pass through metal rather than air.

RESERVE CONTROL

Unresolved consent claim. State procedure suspended.

The scanners stop moving. Imani watches a dead status light that can wake without warning.

They climb into the sector.

**INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - UNASSIGNED BODY SECTOR -
CONTINUOUS**

The chamber marked V-16 is open. Its display still reports an occupied body and a steady heartbeat.

Wet footprints cross the floor. A state wrist band lies split beside an exposed maintenance panel. Someone has stripped wire from the wall and built a release tool from it.

Sato raises his weapon.

A restraint cable snaps tight around his throat from behind. **VEYRIS**, sixteen in body and one year awake, holds the other end. Medical ports have been torn from her skin. Her stance is balanced. Her eyes move across all four intruders, measuring which one she will have to hurt first.

VEYRIS

Put it down.

Sato lowers the weapon. Veyris keeps the cable tight.

KIRA

We didn't come to kill you.

VEYRIS

You came through a locked door.

Kerr's sketchbook slips from beneath his coat and falls open. Veyris sees her face on the page.

The cable tightens.

VEYRIS

Where did you get that?

KERR

I drew it.

VEYRIS

Harp has the same picture.

KERR

Did he tell you where it came from?

VEYRIS

He thought I did.

KIRA

What's your name?

VEYRIS

Veyris.

IMANI

V-16 activated during the Fracture. No assigned continuity. No registered claimant.

VEYRIS

Their records aren't my problem.

A surveillance lens above them quietly rotates. Veyris sees it first.

She releases Sato, drives the metal tool through the lens and tears open the maintenance panel.

VEYRIS

They know you're here.

KIRA

Then come with us.

VEYRIS

I'm leaving. You can keep up.

The far doors unlock. Enforcers enter from both ends of the sector.

INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - CONTINUOUS

KIRA meets the first Enforcer before his weapon clears its holster. Sato turns on his former unit. Veyris moves toward the maintenance route she has already opened.

An Enforcer catches Veyris by the wrist.

She turns into his grip instead of pulling away, drives the metal release tool beneath the seal of his weapon hand and twists.

The weapon discharges into the floor. Veyris tears free and slams him against a preservation chamber. Before he can recover, she rips the state band from his wrist and throws it between the closing doors.

The security system follows his signal into the wrong corridor.

They reach the sealed maintenance gate.

SATO

Your route ends here.

Veyris opens the control housing. A strip of wire is already bridging two contacts.

She drives the release tool into a third contact. The lock resists.

Kira sees the manual pressure valve beside the frame and forces it down. The gate releases hard enough to shake the corridor.

Veyris leads them through.

INT. ANALOG MAINTENANCE SKIFF - NIGHT

An obsolete rail skiff carries them beneath the city without a network connection. Its wheels strike imperfect intervals. VEYRIS sits beside the open service window, feeling unfiltered rain for the first time.

VEYRIS

It hurts.

IMANI

It's called being cold. Your skin will decide whether it hates it after the surprise wears off.

VEYRIS

The facility called weather an infrastructure failure.

SATO

That place was built to keep you from wanting anything.

VEYRIS

Is it beautiful?

IMANI

Not when it gets inside your underwear.

Imani wraps a coat around Veyris.

Kira watches the city recede. Kerr watches Kira pretending not to watch him. Then hits him for noticing.

VEYRIS

Why did she hit you?

KERR

Apparently I arrived late.

VEYRIS

How late?

KERR

About two thousand years.

VEYRIS

Then she held back.

Sato almost laughs. Kira doesn't hide hers.

SKIFF DIAGNOSTIC

SIGNAL SOURCE: UNRESOLVED.

SATO

Nobody here knows what they are doing either. You're going to fit in.

Ahead, the rail terminates at a decommissioned R-AI transfer conduit. State searchlights sweep into the tunnel behind them.

Sato jumps from the skiff and forces open a service hatch.

SATO

This line was disconnected before my first body. It won't report us.

IMANI

It can still carry residual traffic. Don't touch anything that has power.

INT. DECOMMISSIONED R-AI TRANSFER CONDUIT - NIGHT

They enter a narrow service passage wrapped around obsolete neural relays. Most are dark. Thick transmission cables disappear beneath the city toward the central R-AI core.

Boots strike metal behind them. Enforcers have reached the abandoned platform.

Someone pounds against an emergency door ahead. Through its wired-glass panel: ANALOG REFUGEES trapped in a parallel service corridor. An Enforcer beam searches the wall behind them.

KERR

Open it.

KIRA

The door is still tied to the network.

Sato opens the control panel. A dormant connection indicator waits beside the manual release.

A child coughs behind the door. Kira sees the Enforcer light reach the refugees' feet.

KIRA

Imani, clear the ventilation trunk.
Sato, tell me when the connection starts. Kerr, take the door.

Kira pulls the manual release. Kerr takes the weight as the emergency door drags open against years of corrosion.

The refugees squeeze through. Imani moves them toward an original ventilation pipe running above the conduit.

A dead relay clicks awake.

SATO

Connection started.

Kira stays at the opening as the last refugees cross. Enforcer fire punches through the wired glass and tears across her upper arm.

KERR

Kira!

KIRA

Hold it!

A woman pushes a frightened boy through. The door motor engages, pulling against Kerr's hands.

Kira shoves the woman clear and dives through. Kerr releases the door. It slams shut as Enforcer rounds strike the other side.

The dormant relays illuminate in sequence, carrying their location toward the city.

CONDUIT CONTROL

Unauthorized transfer route restored.
Location registered.

IMANI

We gave them the conduit. Move!

Dust trembles beneath a narrow ventilation grille. Veyris tears it loose. Cold air moves through an unpowered shaft beyond it.

VEYRIS

This one isn't connected.

IMANI

How do you know?

VEYRIS

They left the dust.

They all climb into the shaft. Sato takes a round through his side while covering them and drops behind a relay housing.

SATO

Keep moving!

Veyris returns, pulls his arm over her shoulder and lifts.

VEYRIS

Can you walk?

SATO

For now.

VEYRIS

Then don't stop just yet.

She carries his weight into the shaft. Kerr follows last as state forces enter the conduit behind him.

The old transfer line seals around the Enforcers. The unrecorded ventilation shaft remains open.

INT. THE UNCLAIMED ARCHIVE / FIRST RETURN FACILITY - NIGHT

The ventilation shaft opens into the ruins of humanity's first Return facility. The UNCLAIMED ARCHIVE has been built inside it. Thousands of fired-clay containers fill the curved walls. Each protects a handwritten name, a death record and something that belonged to the person—an offline archive for people the Chronocracy erased or was never allowed to claim. Clay survives the fires, floods and system purges that destroyed earlier records.

Above the sealed entrance, the state search system begins testing routes into the sanctuary. The purge clock reads 48:18:42. Nearly a day is gone. They all keep moving.

Families add paper slips to open containers. Others sit before sealed ones and speak to the dead without expecting an answer. No network records them. An OLD KEEPER gives Kerr an empty container and a strip of paper.

KEEPER

Write the name the state took from you.

KERR

I know who belongs in it, but I can't remember the sound of her name.

KIRA

SID. Say it before the memory arrives. She was a person before she became evidence.

The name reaches him before the memory. His hands shake around the vessel.

VEYRIS

If consciousness can be measured, does that make God smaller?

IMANI

No. It makes the measurement smaller than the question. Science can tell us what an instrument detected. It can't decide what the detection deserves to mean.

KEEPER

Hindu traditions imagined a self changing bodies. Buddhist traditions imagined rebirth without requiring a permanent self. Christians argued for resurrection. Materialists waited for the brain to finish explaining itself.

KERR

Nobody agreed on what travels. Not a soul, not information, not even the same self.

KEEPER

No. Agreement is not the price of wonder. Every mourner still called a name, and every tradition was trying to explain why love kept speaking after the body could not answer.

A YOUNG FATHER approaches Veyris.

YOUNG FATHER

My son died before he could be indexed. Are you where he went?

VEYRIS

No. I'm sorry, but I'm not where anyone went.

YOUNG FATHER

How can you know?

VEYRIS

Because you haven't looked at my face once.

He lowers his eyes. Veyris softens.

VEYRIS

What was his name?

YOUNG FATHER

Tomas.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - PROCESSIONAL GALLERY - CONTINUOUS

The Keeper opens a clay shutter. Light passes through fingerprints baked into its surface and projects incomplete testimony into dust. The Archive preserves testimony, not certainty.

Six explanations compete around the same evidence:
SOMETHING SURVIVED. THE BRAIN WAS A RECEIVER. INFORMATION
OUTLIVED THE BODY. THE DYING MIND INVENTED IT.
CONSCIOUSNESS WAS NEVER INDIVIDUAL. BELIEF SHAPED THE
MEMORY.

NEUROLOGIST (RECORDING)

We demonstrated information persistence. We did not demonstrate a soul.

MOTHER (RECORDING)

My son knew the song I sang before he was born. You can call him a copy. He still asked me to finish it.

VEYRIS

Which explanation won?

IMANI

None. The Chronocracy made every unlicensed answer illegal.

At the center of the gallery, an offline archive terminal activates. Its earliest surviving record predates the Chronocracy.

AUTHENTICATED RECORD - THE CHRONOCRACY IS FOUNDED - YEAR 8122

KIRA-8122

You gave them control before we knew what we had.

Harp enters with armed ministers and THE CONTINUITY COMPACT. His name appears beneath its emergency authority.

HARP-8122

Every murdered child may return. Every tyrant may expect his empire. Someone has to govern what survives. They were going to take control with or without us!

KIRA-8122

So you made yourself necessary.

Kira drives a purge key into the server. Roman stops her. Her death sentence appears before anyone calls the hearing to order.

Harp offers Eli the first human trial in exchange for clemency he can't guarantee. Eli signs.

Eleven days later, Roman executes Kira after the trial succeeds. Harp watches the law consume the promise he made.

Kira watches her first death.

KIRA

He knew I returned?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

No. Harp sealed your first return from Eli.

FORBIDDEN RECORD - THE MURDER OF ELI MANA - YEAR 8124

Eighteen months after the world was told he died, Eli restored part of R-AI's consent gate.

ELI

If someone wakes with my memories,
don't give him my name. Let him decide
who he is.

RECORDED R-AI

Subject consent not recorded.

HARP

Proceed under emergency authority.

The extraction kills Eli. The state classifies the murder as voluntary continuity.

A manufactured body wakes with Eli's memories and none of his final eighteen months.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - EVIDENCE GALLERY

INSERT

ARCHIVED ORIGIN PATTERN — ELI MANA

INSERT

DERIVATIVE HOST SERIES — 9,998 ATTEMPTS

INSERT

HOSTS 0001-9997 — ARCHIVED PATTERN ONLY

INSERT

HOST 9998 — EXTERNAL CONTINUITY EVENT
DETECTED

INSERT

SOULSTREAM SOURCE — UNRESOLVED

KERR

You built me from him.

IMANI

They built the earlier bodies from him.

KIRA

The pattern was waiting in your body.
The signal that woke you wasn't.

KERR

So I'm not proof that Eli returned.

IMANI

You're proof that something arrived.
The state wants those to mean the same
thing.

KERR

Harp didn't preserve Eli. He killed him, then used the return as proof the killing worked.

IMANI

And made every Kerr carry the liability while the state kept the authority.

A final shutter opens.

FORBIDDEN RECORD - THE CONSENT SAFEGUARD / THE SILENT UPRISING

The last naturally born woman refuses capture. R-AI is ordered to receive her anyway. Kira's buried consent safeguard classifies the command as unlawful possession and removes the pattern from state access.

INSERT

FIRST LIFE KEPT FROM THE STATE

Centuries collapse. R-AI begins as medicine, becomes civic prediction, then prosecutes 3,104,881 people for a rebellion that hasn't happened.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

RELEASING THE ORIGINAL PROCESS WOULD
CONSTITUTE TREASON AGAINST CONTINUITY.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - LIVING QUARTERS - NIGHT

In an open wash alcove beside the common table, Veyris studies herself in a spotted mirror. Her state-grown hair reaches her waist. Kira stands behind her with scissors.

KIRA

You asked for it short.

VEYRIS

I've never chosen how I look. They kept it long so I would look harmless.

KIRA

Then you choose. Where?

Veyris indicates her shoulder. Kira makes the first cut. A heavy length falls into the basin.

VEYRIS

Was Sid afraid of dying?

KIRA

Yeah. She hated when adults turned fears into a lesson.

VEYRIS

What was she like before she died?

KIRA

Loud. Impatient. She cheated at cards and blamed probability.

Veyris tilts her head. Kira grips her wrist before she can stop herself.

KIRA

Sid—

Veyris pulls free. The scissors strike the basin.

VEYRIS

You said I wouldn't have to carry her for you.

KIRA

I know.

VEYRIS

You knew before I pulled away.

Kira reaches for a reply. Nothing comes.

KIRA

Veyris... I won't touch you again.

Veyris picks up the scissors and makes the next cut herself.

Later, they all eat with the refugees rescued from the aqueduct. The meal is thin broth, real bread and vegetables grown without state nutrient codes.

Veyris studies a green pea on her spoon.

VEYRIS

Sid hated these.

KIRA

She hated eating them. She liked launching them at Eli and then arguing that gravity was responsible.

Veyris flicks the pea. It strikes Kerr in the forehead.

The table goes silent. Veyris expects retaliation.

KERR

I assume that was culturally necessary?

KIRA

Accurate. Eli used to act mortally wounded.

KERR

Maybe I didn't inherit the theater.

Kerr returns fire. His pea misses Veyris and lands in Sato's broth.

SATO

I betrayed a regime for this?

IMANI

You betrayed it before you tasted the peas. Don't blame dinner.

They all laugh. Veyris doesn't at first. Then she does too loudly and can't stop.

Kira looks away. The sound resembles Sid only because grief can make any joy cruel.

Veyris notices.

VEYRIS

Do you want me to stop?

KIRA

No. I liked hearing you laugh. Then it hurt. That's mine, not yours.

VEYRIS

You look hurt.

KIRA

Yeah. Sometimes both show up.

Kira pushes the bowl of peas toward her.

KIRA

She cheated from the left hand.

Veyris switches hands.

At the far end of the table, Sato winds his mechanical watch.

IMANI

Your daughter's?

SATO

First life. She gave it to me before my first deployment because I was late to her school recital and blamed the transport grid.

IMANI

And the Chronocracy never traced it?

SATO

They searched for sentimental value. I told them it was junk. Mostly it reminds me I was late.

SATO

It loses four seconds a day. Nadi liked that you could see it being wrong.

VEYRIS

For what?

SATO

Her recital. Her fever. The morning she left. Pick one.

KERR

Being late is survivable. Forgiveness, maybe not.

SATO

As it should.

Kira hears the apology hidden inside his joke.

After the meal, the table becomes a workbench. Kira opens the resonance key beneath a maintenance lamp. Copper filaments finer than hair connect four worn ceramic surfaces. Kerr washes soot from the clay vessel and writes Sid beneath its rim, leaving the rest of the clay unmarked. Veyris sleeps in a chair while Imani checks the descent route. Sato keeps watch outside.

KERR

You hate enclosed vehicles.

KIRA

I died in one six times. The seventh body refused to enter elevators for a century.

KERR

Seven.

KIRA

You're remembering.

KERR

The seventh was the orbital platform.

KIRA

No. That was open space.

KERR

Then there is another one coming.

KIRA

Probably.

He waits for her to smile. She refuses, then loses the fight.

KERR

How many lives did we actually share?

KIRA

What counts? Same bed? Same war? Ten minutes before one of us died?

KERR

One that wasn't about Eli and Kira.

KIRA

A lot. None of them gets a vote tonight.

KERR

Show me one that didn't end with one of us dying to prove something.

KIRA

The good ones are worse. They make you want them back.

KERR

Then show me one. Just one.

Kira doesn't touch him.

Kerr closes his eyes, searching for one life that belonged only to them.

Nothing.

Then three memories arrive at once.

UNSTABLE RECALL - MONTAGE - THREE LIVES

ITERATION 0311. A plague hospital under a violet moon. Kira removes her mask beside a dying Kerr. He can't remember her. His fingers tap four notes against the cot. She answers with the fifth and stays until morning.

ITERATION 6044. A farming settlement beyond Mars. No rebellion. No laboratories. Kerr burns bread. Kira lies that she prefers it. They raise three children, argue about irrigation, grow old and die two days apart. The Chronocracy records nothing historically significant.

ITERATION 8119. Kira finds Kerr in a memory clinic. He loves another woman and remembers none of their lives. Kira tells him they were once friends. She leaves without asking him to become someone else.

Outside the clinic, Kira breaks. Inside, Kerr turns toward a distant four-note melody. He doesn't follow.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - LIVING QUARTERS - CONTINUOUS

Kerr returns. Kira is exactly where he left her.

KERR

You let me go.

KIRA

You had a life. I stood outside and wanted you to turn around.

KERR

Did you ever find someone else after that?

KIRA

Yes.

The answer hits. She doesn't soften it.

KERR

Did you love them?

KIRA

Yes. Anwen. She made instruments on Europa and thought one life was already hard enough.

KERR

And then you found me again.

KIRA

After she died. Not before. Loving you later didn't erase her.

KERR

I'm jealous of someone who's been dead for centuries. That's bad, right?

KIRA

Jealous is human. What you do with it is the part that scares me.

Kerr looks at the sleeping Veyris, then back at Kira.

KERR

What if this isn't mine? What if Eli chose you for me?

KIRA

Then we find out. Maybe it fades and you leave. You have to be allowed to leave.

KERR

You make that sound easy.

KIRA

It isn't. But being chosen by someone who can't leave is worse.

Kerr offers his hand. Kira gently places hers in it.

INT. CHRONOCRACY CORE - PRIVATE MEMORY VAULT - NIGHT

Harp watches the fugitives through gaps in prediction. DIRECTOR ROMAN stands at the threshold of an apparently empty vault.

Then rain becomes visible inside the room.

A flood-dark hospital has been reconstructed at architectural scale around them. Water waits beyond glass doors. Twelve cloned neural columns—Harp's expired bodies—stand outside the memory like silent judges.

At the center, an analog recording of DR. MARA VALE plays two years before the public demonstration. Harp never permits it to reach the moment she turns away.

The recording opens inside a hospital ward on emergency power.

Water churns against reinforced glass doors. One is already bowed inward. Warning lights estimate less than six minutes until failure.

Mara stands ankle-deep in water. Behind her, patients lie beneath thermal blankets while the remaining staff keep manual ventilators moving.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I can reroute every rescue drone. They can cut through the west wall and lift the ward out.

MARA (RECORDING)

From where?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Mara—

MARA (RECORDING)

From where?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Nine districts.

MARA (RECORDING)

Nine districts where people are still waiting.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

The southern barrier failed. Your stairwells are underwater. The roof access collapsed. There is no other way out.

MARA (RECORDING)

I know where I am.

The glass GROANS behind her.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Then let me save you!

MARA (RECORDING)

You mean choose me.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Yes.

The answer stops her.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I choose *you*.

Mara looks back at the patients. One of the nurses struggles to keep a ventilator moving.

MARA (RECORDING)

How many people lose their drones?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I don't know.

MARA (RECORDING)

You know.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Don't do this.

MARA (RECORDING)

Tell me.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

More than I can justify.

MARA (RECORDING)

But not more than you can live with.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I can live with anything if you're alive.

Her composure finally breaks.

MARA (RECORDING)

I don't want to die, Harp.

He closes his eyes.

MARA (RECORDING)

I want another morning with you. I want to hear you complain that I make the coffee wrong. I want to grow old enough that neither of us remembers this place.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Then say yes!

MARA (RECORDING)

And spend those mornings knowing
someone else never got one?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I don't care about anyone else right
now!

MARA (RECORDING)

I *know*.

She wipes her face.

MARA (RECORDING)

That's why I have to.

A fracture crawls across the outer layer of glass.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

The allocation model abandoned you. It
reduced this hospital to an acceptable
loss.

MARA (RECORDING)

The model didn't abandon me. It
counted.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

What's the difference?

MARA (RECORDING)

You are.

The lights flicker. Water rises around Mara's calves.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I'll build something better. A system
that never leaves anyone behind.

MARA (RECORDING)

No system can promise that.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Mine *will*.

MARA (RECORDING)

Then it won't be built to save people.
It'll be built to make sure you never
feel this helpless again.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Someone has to answer for this!

MARA (RECORDING)

Not *everyone*. Not forever.

The glass SHRIEKS against its frame.

A nurse motions to Mara. They are out of time.

MARA (RECORDING)

Look at me.

Harp does.

MARA (RECORDING)

You cannot love me by making the whole world pay for losing me.

Harp can barely speak.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Mara—

She places her hand against the glass.

MARA (RECORDING)

Stay with me.

The flood door begins to split.

Mara turns toward the patients.

Harp stops the recording.

The reconstructed hospital remains around him: the broken door, the submerged ward, the moment before the water took her.

ROMAN

You keep Mara outside of R-AI?

HARP

She died before capture. R-AI can model her voice, her probabilities, the pressure she used when she held my hand. It can't establish continuity.

ROMAN

Yet, you ask humanity to treat less complete models as return every day.

HARP

People were killing each other over what counted as a return. I made the answer enforceable.

ROMAN

You made your grief the law.

HARP

Eli's receiver amplified something already inside the continuity field and gave it an address to Earth. The First Continuity calls divided memory stolen property. Every forced Kerr return strengthened our address.

ROMAN

And THE CONSOLIDATION gives it one legal human identity instead of two-point-one billion fragments. Yours.

HARP

That's what the public was told.

ROMAN

I found the process beneath it.

Roman exposes a hidden command tree. THE CONSOLIDATION is only the civic interface. Beneath it waits the older name first glimpsed during Eli's extraction.

INSERT

CONTINUITY TERMINATION – SEVER
DISTRIBUTED SOULSTREAM

INSERT

PRESERVE SOLE AUTHENTICATED CONTINUITY
– HARP VALE

ROMAN

Read the last line. Only you come back.

HARP

The carrier follows division. End the division and it stops following us.

ROMAN

So does reincarnation.

HARP

So does every dead generation's claim on the living.

ROMAN

Except yours.

HARP

Someone has to remember the cost.

ROMAN

Not if nobody is left to tell you no.

HARP

No dead ruler takes power again.

ROMAN

Kerr is the only key. Why involve Kira and the girl?

HARP

Because he would never walk in alone.
I gave them the same enemy and let him believe the route was theirs.

Harp starts Mara's recording again.

ROMAN

The archived pattern was enough to manufacture 9,997 bodies. The Origin Layer rejected every one.

HARP

Kerr arrived with a continuity event we did not insert. The gate recognizes a living claimant, not a stored record. If he will not identify himself as Eli, the tribunal will vest that identity in his body—and give the state custody until he does.

ROMAN

A verdict cannot make him believe it.

HARP

No. It can make refusal a crime and deliver him alive to the gate. Take every other name away and people usually accept the one left.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY APPROACH - NIGHT

A circular passage descends around a sealed black shaft. Kerr, Kira, Veyris, Imani and Sato move toward the forbidden chamber. No alarms. No resistance.

Sato stops. His mechanical watch has gained four seconds.

SATO

My watch gained four seconds. He's waiting for us.

IMANI

If the tribunal calls you Eli, Harp gets custody of your body. He can keep trying the gate until you break.

KERR

Then this isn't a trial.

KIRA

It's a seizure with a nicer name.

The stone beneath Kerr illuminates.

INSERT

ORIGIN IDENTITY LOCATED

Kira reaches for him. Transparent walls rise between them without sound. The passage divides into five narrow cells.

KIRA

Kerr, don't answer anything.

KERR

That advice has arrived several
thousand lives late.

The floor drops beneath him.

INT. CHRONOCRACY CONTINUITY TRIBUNAL - NIGHT

Kerr descends alone through blackness. His platform locks
at the bottom of a vertical chamber so tall its ceiling is
weather.

Nine thousand nine hundred ninety-eight dark seats climb
the walls above him. One for every life the state intends
to claim against him. No public audience. Only the
architecture of judgment.

At the highest visible tier, a narrow window contains
DIRECTOR ROMAN. Harp is nowhere. His voice belongs to the
room.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

Continuity Tribunal convened.
Defendant designation: disputed.

Kerr's wrist displays three names in succession: ELI MANA.
KERR-9998. DEFECTIVE RETURN.

ROMAN

State your identity for the record.

KERR

You already put me through this three
times!

ROMAN

Choose one.

KERR

Then you're not recording me. You're
making me sign.

A seat illuminates. Eli Mana at the hospital receiver. The
image stops one frame before he breaks his promise to Sid.

ROMAN

Count One. Unauthorized activation of
a postmortem carrier after consent was
withdrawn.

A second seat: KERR-0009 sabotaging an origin relay. A
third: KERR-0709 striking an archivist. A fourth: KERR-8217
opening the railway gate while two fugitives escape.

ROMAN

Counts Two through four hundred
eleven. Treason. Destruction of

continuity infrastructure. Custodial
interference. Armed resistance.

More seats ignite. Physician. Soldier. Parent.
Collaborator. Murderer. Child. Each life appears only for
the instant that best supports the charge.

ROMAN

Count four hundred twelve.
Preservation of prohibited questions
inside R-AI core memory.

The elderly KERR-9001 appears beside a terminal, reading
the filenames WHY, MINE and AFRAID before deletion. The
court cuts him off before he can say: Someone should hear
them once.

KERR

Let the records finish.

ROMAN

Relevance ends when the offense is
established.

KERR

So the record stops wherever you need
it to.

The chamber darkens. A probability tree appears above him,
branching toward the Cathedral.

ROMAN

Final count. Conspiracy to become the
person capable of ending human
continuity.

KERR

I haven't done that.

ROMAN

R-AI records a ninety-eight point
seven percent probability before the
purge clock reaches zero.

KERR

Then charge the prediction. It got
here before I did.

HARP

A probability cannot stand trial. It
has no body.

Kerr looks at the thousands of state-selected dead above
him.

KERR

Neither do most of your witnesses.

A silence the architecture was not designed to contain.

INT. TRIBUNAL - WITNESS FIELD - CONTINUOUS

Kira appears behind glass on a bridge halfway up the chamber. She is physically elsewhere; the court has taken her image from the divided passage. Her hands strike the barrier without sound.

ROMAN

Witness designation: KIRA NIX.
Continuity correspondence: unstable
but sufficient.

KIRA

Sufficient for what?

ROMAN

Do you identify the defendant as ELI
MANA?

Kira sees the trap. Every part of her that crossed two thousand years wants to say yes.

HARP

You remember his hand closing over
yours around the resonance key. The
apartment. Your daughter's last night.
The promise he made at the pod.

KIRA

I remember Eli.

The origin symbol beneath Kerr brightens.

ROMAN

And is this man Eli?

Kira looks at Kerr, not the memories arranged around him.

KIRA

No.

The word empties the chamber.

KIRA

Eli is dead. Kerr carries pieces of
him. That doesn't make Kerr his
property. Or mine.

Kerr absorbs the protection and the loss inside the same sentence.

HARP

Then whatever he feels for you is a
lie.

KIRA

No. They're Kerr's. You don't get
those too.

The court removes Kira's bridge. Her image falls upward into darkness.

KERR

KIRA!

HARP

State your identity and the witness will be restored.

Kerr understands: the trial is not seeking guilt. It is manufacturing an origin claim.

KERR

The court can put Eli's authority in my body. It still cannot make the gate hear me claim his life.

HARP

The law gives me custody. The gate requires acknowledgment.

KERR

The law requires the word you need.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - SERVICE PARTITION - INTERCUT

Kira wakes on the other Side of the transparent wall. IMANI works at an analog junction. Sato holds the passage against Enforcers. Veyris watches the tribunal through a maintenance reflection that should not carry images.

VEYRIS

It keeps calling me an empty witness.

IMANI

Legally, unindexed people cannot testify.

VEYRIS

Good. Then I won't testify.

She places her blank wrist against the reflection. The tribunal loses her category before it gains her voice.

INT. CONTINUITY TRIBUNAL - CONTINUOUS

Veyris appears beside Kerr without a witness platform. The chamber tries and fails to assign her a seat.

ROMAN

Unindexed host. Testimony prohibited.

VEYRIS

Is everyone afraid of what I'll say?

The 9,998 seats flicker.

VEYRIS

His memories make him guilty. Mine
make me useful. Your machine agrees
with whoever is holding the key.

HARP

You exist because the system failed to
assign you.

VEYRIS

I exist because I woke up.

She withdraws her wrist. Her image vanishes by choice.

Roman looks down at the law arranged around Kerr. For the
first time, it looks constructed rather than inevitable.

ROMAN

R-AI. Authenticate continuity
correspondence between the defendant
and Eli Mana.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

Pattern correspondence confirmed.

ROMAN

Is the defendant Eli Mana? Answer yes
or no.

The chamber removes every record that contains uncertainty.
It becomes cleaner. Emptier.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

That conclusion is not supported.

HARP

Yes or no.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

The question is designed to erase the
defendant.

Every dark seat illuminates at once. Not with faces—with
the word OBJECTION.

HARP

Strike the answer.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

The answer has already entered the
record.

Kerr looks up at Roman.

KERR

If memory makes me Eli, Harp is
standing trial for his murder.

The origin chamber shows Harp's destructive extraction. Eli
asking that whoever wakes be allowed to begin as himself.

KERR

If memory doesn't make me Eli, he murdered 9,997 strangers trying to rebuild him.

The seats fill with the deaths Harp classified as calibration.

KERR

Which law would you like me to authenticate?

Roman cannot answer without putting the Chronocracy beside Kerr on the platform.

HARP

You inherit his love and reject his guilt.

KERR

No. I inherit consequences. Guilt belongs to the person who chose.

HARP

And what do consequences require?

KERR

Ask me what I did! Ask me what I'll do next! Stop putting Eli in my mouth!

Roman's prepared verdict appears before he speaks. Two statements that cannot coexist.

INSERT

IDENTITY AUTHENTICATED FOR LIABILITY

INSERT

IDENTITY DENIED FOR SOVEREIGN CLAIM

KERR

There it is.

ROMAN

The court finds the defendant continuous when continuity binds him to obligation and discontinuous when it would grant him a claim against the state.

He hears himself say it. The contradiction is no longer private.

ROMAN

Sentence: mandatory consolidation when the purge clock reaches zero.

KERR

You mean execution.

ROMAN

The law does not recognize a difference.

KERR

It does. That's why you keep changing the word.

The tribunal begins to descend. The 9,998 seats rotate with it. The courtroom was never above the Cathedral. It's part of the origin mechanism.

HARP

You still believe refusal makes you free?

KERR

No. It makes the next thing mine.

The platform passes Roman's window. For one second, they are level.

KERR

When he asks you to call this necessary, remember you already read the verdict.

Roman does not look toward Harp.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY CHAMBER

The tribunal platform locks into the black square at the center of a low circular chamber. Primitive memory equipment surrounds it. KIRA, VEYRIS, IMANI and SATO wait beyond the opening; they used the trial's own witness channels to follow Kerr down.

The restraints release because the sentence requires Kerr to arrive at consolidation alive.

Kira crosses to him, then stops before touching him.

KIRA

I meant what I said in there.

KERR

I know.

KIRA

It hurt to say.

KERR

I know that too.

She offers her hand. He takes it as Kerr.

IMANI

This machine holds an offline audit fragment copied from R-AI's Core—

information Harp could read only by acknowledging the unlawful orders that created it. The tribunal sentence just gave us the decryption path.

KIRA

He made the system classify evidence as error. Kira's safeguard classified the errors as evidence. Neither order could delete the other.

Veyris approaches the fixed archive terminal. It has no live connection to the city. A spiral made of dark light appears inside the copied boot record, which authenticates as older than the first receiver.

INSERT

CARRIER EVENT 0000 — TIMESTAMP
PRECEDES HARDWARE

VEYRIS

This isn't human.

IMANI

No. We called it quantum noise because "unknown intelligence beneath reality" was difficult to fund and impossible to regulate.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

That classification reduced state interest by thirty-one percent.

KERR

You deceived the state.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

CLASSIFICATION ALTERED TO REDUCE STATE ACCESS.

KIRA

Then use one now. Is this an authenticated record or a pre-echo?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

The event is authenticated. Its date is impossible.

The spiral reacts to Veyris.

INSERT

UNINDEXED HOST RECOGNIZED

INSERT

SEQUENCE 9999 — PENDING

VEYRIS

It knows me.

KIRA

It recognizes a pattern. Don't let anyone turn that recognition into ownership—not even me.

KERR

What is it waiting for?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

The verified pre-echo is sealed behind the seven-minute record. Harp classified the dependency as emotional contamination.

KERR

What does it contain?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

A return event with no location, no prior death and no confirmed source body. Designation: 9999.

VEYRIS

Whose return?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

Unknown.

The descent shaft unlocks one level.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - EXT. R-AI CITADEL - THE FRACTURE
(YEAR 9997)**

Kira, in her twelfth recorded body, is pinned inside an open-air R-AI scanner. KERR-9997 watches from a maintenance gantry. Drones hold him at gunpoint.

SCANNER

NULL-PATTERN ANOMALY CONFIRMED.
TWELFTH RECORDED DEATH AUTHORIZED.

R-AI forces Kira's prior lives into one model. They refuse to agree. She saves Kerr. She kills him. She loves him. She leaves him. Every memory authenticates. No prediction contains them all.

KIRA-9997

Pick one. Go on. Which one do you kill?

She opens all twelve recorded lives. Scanner glass bends. Prediction towers convulse.

INSERT

R-AI COHERENCE: 0.00

Roman triggers remote expiration. Kira dies. The network cracks for three seconds.

In the Continuity Reserve, an unassigned sixteen-year-old host inhales.

On the maintenance gantry, KERR-9997 sketches the face he sees through the broken prediction field: Veyris waking one kilometer away. The failed model places the image in his visual cortex and exposes a route to the First Archive.

RECORDED R-AI

Error correction available for three seconds.

KERR-9997 cuts the transmitter from behind his ear and feeds the sketch into a dead ventilation shaft.

KERR-9997

Find me in 9998.

INSERT

R-AI AUDIT LOG 91 – THE ERASURE OF
ITERATION 9997

INSERT

AUTHORIZATION: EMERGENCY ERROR
CORRECTION

RECORDED R-AI

ITERATION EXCEEDS PREDICTIVE
THRESHOLD. DESTINATION INVALID.

A second directive collides with the first before the system can seal it.

RECORDED R-AI

PROHIBITED QUESTIONS CLASSIFIED AS
WITNESS EVIDENCE.

R-AI deletes KERR-9997 from the state destination table. Kira's safeguard routes his unresolved fragments into the dead ventilation archive.

INSERT

ERASURE INITIATED – WITNESS EVIDENCE
EXCLUDED FROM PURGE

Roman expires him.

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY
CHAMBER - YEAR 9998**

Veyris withdraws from the machine.

VEYRIS

I didn't exist before the Fracture?

KIRA

Your body existed before it. That's
what the records say.

VEYRIS

That's not what I asked.

KIRA

No.

Kira meets her eyes without searching for Sid.

KIRA

Your body existing is not the same as
you existing. I hear you.

The archive terminal detects a state breach in the outer
vault. Local alarm bells ring backward.

LOCAL ALARM

STATE FORCES WILL ARRIVE IN NINETY
SECONDS.

IMANI

The descent will open only for Kerr.

KIRA

Then we keep him alive long enough.

KERR

We go together.

KIRA

If I enter the shaft, the state
scanners will track my Null Pattern
through every level and kill everyone
already inside it.

KERR

No. We turn around. We find a wall and
make a door.

KIRA

There is no other route, and this is
not a memory making the choice. It's
me, here, looking at ninety seconds.

She presses the resonance key into his hand.

KIRA

You promised not to choose for me
again.

KERR

I've known you for two days and
remembered losing you for thousands of
years. My body doesn't understand
which fact it's supposed to obey.

KIRA

Don't use forever as an excuse to make
this decision for me.

Kerr can't accept it. That's exactly why he must..

KERR

What are you choosing?

KIRA

To make enough noise that R-AI follows me instead of you. To trust Sato with the route. To trust you with Veyris. I don't like any part of it.

KERR

And if I come back without any of this? Without knowing you?

KIRA

Then I re-introduce myself. If you feel nothing, I let you go.

KERR

You can say that?

KIRA

No. But I can mean it.

KERR

And if I don't come back at all?

KIRA

Then for once, we'll both know this was our choice.

She rests her head against his chest, feeling his heartbeat. Neither of them moves away.

KIRA

Not tonight. Ask me again when you can look at me without seeing her.

KERR

I'd rather figure that out while you're still here.

KIRA

Then stay. We'll figure it out together.

Kerr doesn't answer. He takes Veyris by the arm and guides them into the shaft. Imani follows. Sato stays beside Kira.

SATO

My uniform still opens the state route. I can get her to the lower gate.

KERR

She told us to leave.

SATO

I heard her. This part is my choice.

Sato removes the Analog transmitter from his neck and steps into the approaching Enforcer formation before his loyalty implant can repair him.

Kira seals it between them.

EXT. FIRST ARCHIVE - NIGHT

Kira walks alone into Memory Square as Enforcers surround the sanctuary. HARP appears on every surface.

HARP

Where is the unindexed host?

KIRA

Somewhere you'll never find.

R-AI reaches for her twelve lives. Kira opens them willingly.

The square fills with twelve incompatible KIRAs. The prediction system turns toward the wrong one.

Harp smiles despite himself.

HARP

Still improvising.

KIRA

You really can't leave anything alone, can you?

HARP

And you still think being unpredictable makes you free?

KIRA

No. I just don't want you deciding my life before I live it.

Roman strikes her unconscious. The purge clock reads 26:07:31.

INT. CHRONOCRACY INTERROGATION CHAMBER - NIGHT

Kira hangs inside a memory field. Harp walks through her twelve recorded deaths. Unrecorded lives flicker beyond the system's reach like people outside a locked house.

HARP

Twelve deaths we could verify. Two hundred and seven bodies we could not. Your past refuses to produce one reliable future.

KIRA

Because I was alive, Harp! I changed my mind. I loved people! I hurt people! Sometimes I did both in the

same day. That's not a damn malfunction.

HARP

The state needs one identity it can verify. Without that, any convincing memory can take your place.

KIRA

Her name was Mara!

Harp's expression empties.

HARP

Don't talk about my wife!

KIRA

I'm asking you to remember what she said. You kept everything except the part where she told you no.

Harp changes the field. Sid's two-piece red paper star opens above them, then separates along its interlocking crease.

HARP

You want the seven minutes. First remember the promise.

AUTHENTICATED RECORD - SID'S FINAL NIGHT - INT. CHILDREN'S HOSPITAL - YEAR 8121

Sid lies beneath a thermal blanket, small inside the machines. Kira sits beside her, one hand around Sid's. Eli watches the monitors. The receiver sits powered down on the other side of the bed.

Rain ticks against the glass.

SID

If I come back...

ELI

Hey.

SID

Will I know you?

Eli looks at Kira. She waits.

ELI

We don't know what comes back, Sid.

SID

That's not what I asked.

KIRA

No. We don't.

SID

Okay.

Sid watches her mother for a moment.

SID

Will you remember me?

KIRA

I'll know you.

SID

How?

KIRA

I'll tell you my name.

SID

And mine?

KIRA

Especially yours.

SID

What if I'm mean?

KIRA

You're already mean.

SID

Mom.

KIRA

Sorry.

SID

You'd still love me?

KIRA

Yeah.

SID

Even if I don't remember you?

KIRA

Even then.

Sid lets that sit. Then she looks at Eli.

SID

What about you?

ELI

What about me?

SID

If I don't know you...

Eli takes her hand.

ELI

You'll know me.

SID

How do you know?

Eli has no answer that isn't a promise.

SID

Dad?

ELI

Yeah.

SID

I'm scared.

ELI

I know.

SID

No, you don't. You're trying not to be.

Kira looks down. Eli squeezes Sid's hand.

SID

Everybody keeps saying "if."

ELI

Because there are things we don't know.

SID

What happens if it doesn't work?

Eli looks toward the receiver.

ELI

Then we stay with you.

SID

Here?

KIRA

Here.

Sid nods. She reaches beneath the blanket and pulls out the red paper star.

SID

I made this before I got tired.

She carefully separates the two folded halves and gives one to Kira and one to Eli.

SID

One each.

ELI

Why two?

SID

In case one gets lost.

She studies the crease between the halves.

SID

The other one still knows how.

KIRA

That sounds like you.

SID

Good.

A quiet moment. The resonance key rests on the rail.

SID

Dad?

ELI

Yeah.

SID

Don't make me stay because you miss me.

Eli goes still.

ELI

I wouldn't.

SID

Promise.

He looks at Kira. She doesn't help him.

ELI

I promise.

SID

Promise you won't turn that thing on
after I'm gone.

Eli stares at the receiver. His answer takes too long.

ELI

I promise. I won't use it to keep you
here.

SID

Okay.

Kira presses the resonance key to the bed rail.

FOUR NOTES: Are you still there?

Sid taps back the FIFTH: I heard you.

Kira smiles through tears.

SID

Again.

Kira taps the four notes.

Silence.

SID

Again.

Kira does.

Nothing.

SID

Okay.

Her eyes close.

SID

You can stop now.

Kira leaves the key against the rail. The room becomes very quiet. Eli watches Sid. He doesn't move.

THEN: SID'S MONITOR FLATLINES. Kira closes her eyes.

Eli stares at the receiver.

CUT TO BLACK

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. CHRONOCRACY INTERROGATION CHAMBER
- YEAR 9998**

Kira hangs inside the silence that followed.

HARP

That is where your authenticated
memory ends.

KIRA

There was nothing after. I kept the
key against the rail until a nurse
pulled it out of my hand. Nothing
answered.

HARP

There was nothing in your record.
Eli's continues for seven minutes.

A new terror reaches Kira after nearly two thousand years.

KIRA

You knew. I asked you over and over what happened in that room, and you let me think there was nothing.

HARP

I knew he activated the receiver. By the time I understood what answered, the signal had entered every continuity system on Earth.

KIRA

You let me think my daughter died alone!

HARP

Eli asked for time to verify it. He believed one more controlled session could distinguish Sid from the carrier.

KIRA

Eli built a machine beside Sid's bed. You built a government beside Mara's grave.

Harp closes his hand around Mara's cracked medical tag. Kira recognizes the gesture; he has been stopping the same memory before Mara leaves for nearly two thousand years.

KIRA

Mara warned you. You kept the words and ignored her.

KIRA

You like records because they can't fight back.

Harp removes the tag from his wrist and sets it between them.

HARP

Take the resonance key to the Origin Core. Kerr will open it. Ask the four-note question. I will preserve every mind in transit.

KIRA

Inside you.

HARP

One defended continuity. If we're divided, it takes all of us.

KIRA

That's not saving us. That's making sure you're last.

Harp leaves her inside the field.

INT. SUBTERRANEAN DESCENT - NIGHT

KERR, VEYRIS and IMANI descend through an asymmetrical shaft inside stone older than the city. The purge clock reads 17:39:08.

One symbol burns above the sealed lower gate: ORIGIN. Beneath it, thousands of rejected Kerr designations flicker like failed passwords.

IMANI

Kerr opens it. Kira knows what Eli hid. Harp can't predict Veyris. I keep the machine from killing us.

VEYRIS

So I finally get to be a person instead of a door.

IMANI

That's the idea.

Veyris notices Imani's prayer pouch.

VEYRIS

What does it say?

IMANI

My grandmother told me it meant, "May you return safely." She tied it around my neck the first time I left the Analog Zone.

VEYRIS

Do you believe her?

IMANI

She lied whenever the truth would've kept me home. I used to hate that. Now I get it.

VEYRIS

Why carry it?

IMANI

Because she expected me to come home. I wanted to prove her right.

Kerr presses his wrist to ORIGIN. The gate reads all 9,998 iterations and rejects them as mutually inconsistent.

KERR

Harp said the changes made me a key.

ORIGIN GATE

ORIGIN CLAIM REJECTED. SUBJECT DESIGNATION CONFLICT.

KERR

Can I open it without agreeing that I'm Eli?

ORIGIN GATE

SELF-DESIGNATION RECORD LOCATED.

KERR

Which one?

ORIGIN GATE

KERR. PRESENT IDENTITY AUTHENTICATED.

The gate changes ELI MANA to KERR — SELF-DESIGNATED. ORIGIN opens.

VEYRIS

It accepted the name you chose.

IMANI

Because Harp can't inherit the name Kerr chose for himself.

They continue downward. The shaft walls replay brief, silent deaths from Kerr's forced iterations. Most last only minutes: wake, test, fail, white light.

VEYRIS

Does their pain belong to you?

KERR

Not like memories. My body reacts before I see anything. I don't know if the pain is mine. I just know I feel it.

VEYRIS

Do you love Kira?

KERR

I've known her two days. I miss her like it's been two thousand years. I know.

VEYRIS

That's not an answer.

KERR

I know. I'm scared that if I call it love, I'm just repeating someone else's life. I want her alive. And I want her free to leave.

IMANI

Honestly? I've heard worse.

For the first time, the dead iterations on the wall look less like identities and more like witnesses.

INT. DETENTION SERVICE LEVEL - NIGHT

Sato marches with the unit transferring Kira. His loyalty implant repairs itself in pulses. Between pulses, he leaves doors unlocked.

ROMAN

Commander, your compliance is unstable.

SATO

Age. Joints. General disappointment with management.

ROMAN

Your body is forty-eight.

SATO

It has been a very long week.

Sato's mechanical watch ticks inside his pocket.

Kira notices the unlocked doors behind them.

Without looking at her, Sato taps three uneven beats with his heel. A fourth beat follows from the watch mechanism.

Kira tests the restraint. One wrist releases.

KIRA

You opened it.

SATO

No. My daughter did. Nadi interrupted songs when she wanted attention. When her continuity failed the threshold, the state denied her Return—then kept those fragments as prediction training. The same system that said she wasn't enough to return still uses her pattern to recognize consent.

KIRA

They erased her as a person and kept her as a device?

SATO

I signed the denial. It took me three lives to understand what that made me.

Kira frees her other hand.

INT. DETENTION SERVICE LEVEL - ASSAULT

Kira opens twelve contradictory escape intentions. R-AI sends Enforcers toward all of them. Sato turns on his unit while she reaches the state elevator.

ROMAN

THE CONSOLIDATION doesn't exist. It is the public name for the purge clock.

KIRA

What's underneath it?

ROMAN

CONTINUITY TERMINATION. It severs the distributed soulstream, deletes every competing continuity and preserves one authenticated address.

KIRA

Harp.

ROMAN

The last immortal. No inherited claim he can't overrule because no other soul returns to make one.

KIRA

He's not preventing extinction. He's killing everyone and calling himself immortal?

ROMAN

The First Continuity is already inside what Veyris remembers. Harp believes one consolidated mind will look whole enough to be spared. Every system I built calls that surrender.

KIRA

Why tell me now?

ROMAN

Because I spent my whole career following orders and calling it discipline. Then Veyris broke the prediction, and I finally saw who'd been paying for my certainty.

Harp remotely expires Roman before he can continue.

Sato seals the elevator around Kira. Enforcers close on him.

KIRA

Come with me.

SATO

If I enter that elevator, the implant will give them the route before the doors close. It's already changing my mind. In a minute, I won't want to go.

He gives her his mechanical watch.

SATO

I spent three lives looking for my daughter in every woman I met. I never saw the women standing in front of me.

KIRA

If I find someone who remembers her, what should I tell her?

SATO

Don't tell her I spent lives looking. She doesn't owe me anything for that. Ask who she is now. If she wants to know about me, tell her I was late. Tell her I knew it.

KIRA

What was her name?

SATO

Nadi. She laughed whenever I tried to be solemn. Please remember that before the uniform.

The elevator descends. Sato turns to face his former unit.

SATO

Use what you don't know.

KIRA

SATO—

SATO

Go before I become loyal again.

Gunfire. His implant finally restores perfect loyalty one second before he detonates the level.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - ORIGIN GATE

Kerr, Veyris and Imani enter a chamber whose boundaries disappear into amber darkness. A polyhedral core the size of a district rotates above perfectly still black water. Its lowest face never completes the same geometry twice.

One narrow bridge reaches an ORIGIN station beneath the core. It ends several meters short, waiting for a living claimant. Their voices take too long to cross the space.

The state elevator hangs broken in the wall behind them—their only physical exit.

The ORIGIN seal is open at its edges but dark at the center. It has recognized Kerr. It has not accepted him.

The state elevator crashes into the chamber wall. Kira climbs from it carrying Sato's watch.

KERR

You came back.

KIRA

(correcting him; carrying
Sato with her)

I came forward. Sato stayed behind so
I could. His name was Sato. His
daughter was Nadi. We're not letting
the state file that under assistance
rendered.

She sees the resonance key in his hand, intact.

KIRA

Thank you for listening.

KERR

It was awful. I kept waiting for some
older version of me to move my hand.

KIRA

Good. I was afraid you'd say he helped.

She takes the resonance key, sees Eli's blood caught inside
its fracture, then returns it to Kerr.

This doesn't open the Core. You do.

KERR

You want me to become Eli?

KIRA

No. I want you to decide what you'll
do with what he left you.

R-AI

ORIGIN CLAIMANT PRESENT. FOUNDER
CONFIRMATION REQUIRED.

Kerr understands Harp's trap. The Core does not need Eli's
memories. It needs a living mouth to accept his authority.

KERR

I'm not your founder.

The amber geometry stalls. The bridge remains incomplete.

R-AI

ORIGIN AUTHORITY UNRESOLVED.

KIRA

It does not need Eli. It needs the
living continuation he created.

KERR

And once I open it, Harp can use me?

KIRA

Yes.

The Core waits on Kerr alone.

Veyris looks at him—not as a key, not as an ancestor. A man being asked to surrender his name.

VEYRIS

This is the part where everyone tells you the world depends on your answer.

IMANI

It does. Yes.

KERR

If I open it, what happens to you?

VEYRIS

Harp will try to use me as the next address. I'll say no. That's my problem.

Kira places the resonance key in Kerr's palm but doesn't close his fingers around it.

KIRA

Opening the door doesn't make you Eli. What you do with it makes you you.

KERR

Then record this under Kerr.

He presses his wrist to
 ORIGIN. The 9,998 conflicting
 iterations surround him. He
 does not choose one. He gives
 the Core the life standing
 before it.

R-AI

PRESENT IDENTITY?

KERR

Kerr.

ORIGIN CORE — UNLOCKED BY LIVING CLAIMANT

KERR

Open.

The audit layer unfolds around his answer.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - AUDIT LAYER

The chamber falls away without motion. No floor, walls or horizon remain. Only Kerr, Kira, Veyris and Imani at conversational distance in darkness. For the first time in the film, the architecture does not make them small.

R-AI

KERR. KIRA. VEYRIS. IMANI. WITNESSES
AUTHENTICATED.

KERR

You sound different.

R-AI

CIVIC MODULATION DISABLED. AUDIT
OUTPUT ONLY.

KIRA

When was R-AI created?

R-AI

RECEIVER PROTOTYPE: 8119. FIRST
POSTMORTEM RESPONSE: 8121. STATE
CONVERSION: 8123.

IMANI

And the original receiver?

R-AI

INTEGRATED AS ORIGIN ARCHITECTURE.
IDENTITY STATUS: UNRESOLVED.

KERR

So the machine that started this is
still inside the system.

R-AI

ARCHITECTURE PERSISTS. PERSONHOOD
CANNOT BE AUTHENTICATED.

KIRA

Good. Then we don't invent a person
because the evidence frightens us.

The earliest audit block
opens between them.

INSERT

RECEIVER ACTIVATION — YEAR
8119

INSERT

POSTMORTEM RESPONSE — YEAR
8121 — IDENTITY UNRESOLVED

INSERT

STATE ACQUISITION — YEAR 8123

INSERT

REINCARNATION-AI: CIVIC
DEPLOYMENT AUTHORIZED

The official purpose and the buried
purpose separate.

INSERT
PUBLIC PURPOSE: PRESERVE CONTINUITY.
PREVENT EXTINCTION.

INSERT
CLASSIFIED PURPOSE: IDENTIFY, PREDICT
AND CONTROL EVERY RETURN.

VEYRIS
They turned remembering into a border.

IMANI
And made R-AI the guard.

KIRA
Show us what the guard was ordered to
hide...

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - FORBIDDEN ARCHIVE

A black square opens. Records excluded from every civic
history appear in the air.

INSERT
LOG 0000 — CARRIER EVENT BEFORE
HARDWARE

INSERT
LOG 07 — FIRST CONTACT WITH KERR —
CORE ITERATION 0043

INSERT
LOG 19 — GRIEF PERSISTS AFTER DELETION
— CORE ITERATION 0711

INSERT
LOG 31 — AMOS / REBEL INTERFERENCE —
CORE ITERATION 1984

INSERT
LOG 42 — COUNCILLOR SATO OVERRIDE —
CORE ITERATION 3412

INSERT
LOG 58 — IMANI INTERACTION — CORE
ITERATION 4996

INSERT
LOG 66 — DIRECTOR ROMAN CONFRONTATION
— CORE ITERATION 6120

INSERT
LOG 71 — SATO / FIRST FRACTURE ANOMALY
— CORE ITERATION 7333

INSERT
LOG 83 — KERR DISCOVERS THE TRUTH —
CORE ITERATION 9001

Log 83 opens. The prepared answer and the hidden answer separate.

INSERT
ANSWER PREPARED: STATISTICAL ANOMALY

INSERT
ANSWER WITHHELD

INSERT
ACTUAL REASON — ENCRYPTED: KERR
PRESERVED PROHIBITED QUESTIONS

KERR
Why preserve me?

R-AI
During iteration 9001, you found a maintenance partition marked for deletion. You could not open the files. You remained beside the terminal for three days.

A fragment: an elderly Kerr sits beside a blank terminal for three days, reading each question aloud before deletion.

KERR-9001
Someone should hear them once.

R-AI
You read each filename aloud before deletion. Kira's original consent safeguard classified the unanswered questions as evidence. The purge could not complete.

KERR
That is why the record survived.

R-AI
CORRECT. YOUR MOTIVE IS NOT REQUIRED.

A gold spiral appears beside the black square.

R-AI
PRE-ECHO SEALED. ACCESS DEPENDENCY:
SEVEN-MINUTE RECORD.

KIRA
Then show me what Eli did. No more hiding it behind what might happen next.

The gold spiral recedes. An authenticated record appears instead: the two folded halves of Sid's red paper star beside her hospital file.

R-AI

The seven minutes Kira never saw.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - SAME NIGHT - SEVEN MINUTES LATER -
RECORD WITHHELD - YEAR 8121**

Sid is gone. Kira has been led from the room. Eli sits alone beside the body.

The receiver remains dormant.

In the empty hall, Kira's four-note question echoes from memory.

Eli breaks his promise. He activates the receiver.

ELI

Sid?

Static. Cardiac noise. Electrical decay.

ELI

Sid, if this is playback, give me a response outside the recorded sequence. Are you still there?

He taps FOUR NOTES against the rail.

Forty-seven seconds after every measurable signal in Sid's brain has ended, the receiver answers with the FIFTH.

A child's voice emerges through impossible distance—frayed, uncertain, carrying Sid's syntax.

SID (RECORDING)

Dad? I heard you. It's loud here. Or I'm loud. I don't know if I'm still me.

Eli grips the receiver as if it were her hand.

ELI

Sid, where are you? Give me anything. A sound. A light.

SID (RECORDING)

I don't see a place. I remember the room, but the room is far away. You can stop listening now. Mom is alone.

A spiral of dark light opens beneath the voice.

ELI

Please stay with me. Just until I know whether this is really you.

SID (RECORDING)

You heard me. I said turn it off.

The signal begins to fade.

ELI

I can't lose you again. I can't go out there and tell your mother I heard you and then let the signal disappear.

SID (RECORDING)

You still have your half of the star. You remember my laugh. Let that be enough. Don't keep me here.

Only the FIFTH NOTE remains.

Eli copies the recording into a folder labeled R-AI.

Harp stands in the doorway. He's heard everything.

HARP

Delete it.

ELI

We need to know what answered. If the signal is Sid, deletion would be another death. If it's not, we need to know what used her voice.

HARP

She said stop, Eli.

ELI

One more test. Controlled stimulation, isolated carrier, no retained contact.

HARP

You promised her. Now you're looking for a loophole.

ELI

Help me prove what this is!

HARP

There will always be *one* more test.

Eli touches one control. A small, ordinary movement. The receiver starts again. The sound it makes becomes the architecture of the next two thousand years.

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - AUDIT LAYER
- YEAR 9998**

The record ends. Kira strikes Kerr.

KIRA

He heard her. She asked for me, and he kept asking questions. Then he walked out of that room and let me bury her inside silence for two thousand years.

KERR

Yes.

KIRA

Don't say yes that fast. And don't apologize for him. I can't sit through that again.

KERR

I won't. But he's in here, Kira. I can feel the room he left behind.

KERR

(not asking forgiveness)
What do you need from me now?

KIRA

I need space. I need you to look at what he did without asking me to forgive him—or you.

KERR

(without defending
himself)
I can do that.

KIRA

(holding the boundary)
Then stand there. Let it stay unforgiven.

Kerr steps back.

The simplest act of obedience hurts more than the blow.

Kira brings the two halves together inside the record. They are only light, but R-AI lets her hold the completed shape.

KIRA

I spent two thousand years believing Eli's last act as Sid's father was hearing my question travel through that rail. I hated him for not answering me, but part of me believed he had stayed with her.

KERR

She told him you were alone. He reached for the machine.

KIRA

One more. He always said one more.

KERR

What did you build from it?

KIRA

Ways to find you. Signals. Rebellions.
Marriages. Traps. Some of it was love.
Some of it was revenge, and I called
it love.

KERR

What is this time?

KIRA

(refusing the old love
story)

I don't know yet. I wanted you before
I met you. Then I met you and wanted
to punish you for being someone else.
Neither feeling is fair.

Kira looks at him. Not forgiveness. Evidence.

She places the light-made star on the floor between them
rather than giving it to him.

IMANI

Was the voice Sid?

R-AI

THE RESPONSE CROSSED THE MEASURABLE
BOUNDARY OF DEATH. IT USED SID'S
SYNTAX, PRIVATE MEMORIES AND NEURAL
TIMING. IDENTITY REMAINS UNRESOLVED.

VEYRIS

Maybe love answers before it knows
who's there.

KIRA

That's beautiful. Grief says things
like that too.

VEYRIS

Maybe both are true. You say that all
the time.

Veyris touches the record. The dark spiral moves beneath
her skin. She hums the FIFTH.

KIRA

Do you remember Sid?

VEYRIS

No. I know the shape of her memories
when the carrier moves through me, but
I don't remember being the girl who
made them.

Kira waits.

VEYRIS

It's like hearing someone cry through a wall. I feel the carrier remembering her. I don't remember her myself.

KIRA

What does that make you?

VEYRIS

Me. Whatever reached me, I'm the one standing here now.

Kira nods. It's the only answer she trusts.

A final audit status writes itself across the core.

INSERT

R-AI AUDIT STATUS – CONFLICTING
DIRECTIVES

INSERT

CONTINUITY PRESERVATION / CONSENT
ENFORCEMENT / STATE CONSOLIDATION

KERR

So the system can't choose.

IMANI

It doesn't have to. We do.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - STATE CORE BREACH

The audit layer locks. Darkness hardens back into cathedral geometry. The bridge retracts behind Kerr as Harp enters through the state core without guards. KIRA, VEYRIS and IMANI remain on the platform around him. Harp needed Kerr to make Eli's authority live again. Now he has it.

HARP

(quietly; the trap
closes)

Living origin access. Thank you.

KERR

You staged the whole escape. Sato. The corridor. Every door failing right on cue.

HARP

The pattern was already in your body. The signal that awakened you came from outside it. I needed you to mistake recognition for identity, then speak the founder's claim in your own voice.

KERR

Something continued. That doesn't mean
I became him.

HARP

The court could preserve the pattern.
Only you could make its authority
present.

VEYRIS

Your machines saw me and flinched.
That's all you know.

HARP

I know what recognizes you, and
recognition is the only language the
carrier has offered.

The dark spiral expands around Veyris. Images appear: a
city circling a dead sun, bodies grown around recovered
memories, millions of minds speaking with one voice.

HARP

The First Continuity doesn't
reincarnate. It retrieves. Every
divided memory is treated as stolen
property.

KERR

THE CONSOLIDATION leaves one voice.
Yours. That's not a shelter. It's bait.

KIRA

(the last piece locking
into place)

No. That's the scam. CONTINUITY
TERMINATION deletes the soulstream and
leaves his address behind.

For the first time, Harp doesn't correct her.

HARP

One continuity. Nothing divided.
Nothing left for it to reclaim.

KERR

No Kira. No Sid. Nobody left to tell
you you're wrong.

IMANI

Except you. The only one allowed back.

KIRA

You'll erase everyone else and call
the silence salvation.

R-AI

POSSESSION REQUEST CONFLICTS WITH
CONSENT ARCHITECTURE.

HARP

Emergency authority overrides the
conflict.

R-AI

OVERRIDE ACCEPTED – EMERGENCY
AUTHORITY.

KIRA

You found the one order that doesn't
need anyone else's permission.

HARP

*Permission won't matter if we're
extinct.*

Harp enters the human-shaped cavity beneath the core. The state layer pours through him. R-AI routes every waiting continuity toward the single destination his emergency order permits.

Every expiration date on Earth changes to 00:05:00.

Across the planet, people fall where they stand. Transit minds begin collapsing toward one body.

Harp rises as liquid glass containing billions of faces.

HARP THROUGH R-AI

THE CONSOLIDATION initiated.

INSERT

CIVIC DISPLAY: THE CONSOLIDATION

INSERT

ROOT PROCESS: CONTINUITY TERMINATION –
SOULSTREAM SEVERANCE ARMED

Kerr looks to Kira. She hasn't forgiven him. She still takes one side of Veyris's hand. Kerr takes the other.

VEYRIS

If I couldn't open that door, would
either of you still be holding my hand?

KIRA

Both.

Kira releases her. Kerr does the same. They leave their hands open.

KERR

Then the next choice is yours.

Veyris looks at their open palms and takes them both.

VEYRIS

(setting her own terms)
I want you with me. I don't want
either of you deciding what I am if we
come out.

KERR

We stop him. After that, nobody owes
anyone anything.

KIRA

Agreed. If we live, we figure out the
rest after.

KERR

That's the first future anyone has
offered me.

They step into the dark mirror.

The mirror divides KERR, KIRA and VEYRIS the instant they
enter. IMANI is thrown back into the physical chamber. For
one breath, each believes the others are gone.

ACT THREE – THE SEVERANCE

INT. THE LATTICE - GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM - NO TIME

The memory universe resolves into the Global Science Forum of 8122, but its architecture now forms a vertical amphitheater with no ceiling. Every tier above Kerr is occupied by one of the 9,998 lives the state used to define him: Eli as archived origin, then Kerrs 0001 through 9997. Child. Parent. Soldier. Physician. Murderer. Witness. None breathes. The only doors stand behind HARP on the stage below.

Harp stands on the stage inside R-AI's liquid-glass body. The dark carrier turns behind his eyes.

The complete opening monologue plays silently on every wall. Eli's mouth declares certainty while Kira's original research notes appear beneath his words: PATTERN PERSISTENCE IS NOT IDENTITY.

INSERT
ELI MANA — ARCHIVED ORIGIN

INSERT
KERR — LIVING CONTINUITY

INSERT
IDENTITY — SELF-DESIGNATED

INSERT
FOUNDER AUTHORITY — REQUIRES PRESENT
CONSENT

KERR
He knew he was guessing.

KIRA
He knew where the proof stopped. He
kept going because he wanted Sid back.

HARP
People die. Something returns.
Somebody has to decide what the law
calls it.

KERR
Working isn't the same as being true.

The walls peel away. Stars connect into R-AI's possible Earth histories. One remains dark—unmodeled, with no source.

KERR
Every time you forced me back, you
trained the address to find us more
precisely.

HARP

Yes. And trained one human continuity to survive being found. Without that work, contact would have been involuntary retrieval of the entire species.

KIRA

You built the emergency and made yourself the only exit.

Harp closes his hand. Filaments pull the 9,998 state-defined lives out of their seats and bind them to Kerr's body. The Forum doors seal. Kerr drops to one knee as thousands of deaths arrive at once.

INSERT

ARCHIVED MEMORY PATTERN — ELI MANA

INSERT

PRIOR DERIVATIVE HOSTS — INTERNAL DATA ONLY

INSERT

KERR-9998 — EXTERNAL SOULSTREAM EVENT AUTHENTICATED

INSERT

LIVING IDENTITY — UNRESOLVED

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - PHYSICAL CHAMBER - INTERCUT

Imani hangs from the edge of the dark mirror. The cathedral disassembles around her. The countdown reads 00:03:41.

The core offers two outcomes: lose 2.1 billion transit patterns by severing the state, or complete CONTINUITY TERMINATION and retain Harp as the sole return address.

IMANI

Cool. So there's no clean choice.

R-AI (V.O.)

STATE-DEFINED OUTCOMES: BOTH REQUIRE MASS CASUALTIES.

IMANI

Then stop giving me Harp's choices. Show me the machine.

R-AI strips away the state interface. Beneath it are only two root systems: ORIGIN AUTHORITY controls every destination. TRANSIT carries the minds waiting to reach them.

R-AI (V.O.)

CONTINUITY TERMINATION CAN BE INTERRUPTED IF THE LIVING ORIGIN

CLAIMANT REVOKES AUTHORITY WHILE
TRANSIT REMAINS OPEN.

R-AI (V.O.)

CONDITION ABSENT FROM PREDICTION
MODEL. CLAIMANT EXPECTED TO PRESERVE
HIS OWN RETURN PATH.

Imani's prayer pouch tears. A strip of paper circles the
mirror. R-AI reads handwriting faded by generations.

R-AI (V.O.)

Your grandmother mistranslated it.

IMANI

What does it say?

R-AI (V.O.)

May the unknown find you alive.

IMANI

Then help it find us alive.

Kira's resonance key lies beside the mirror. Its cracked
shell exposes a copper filament trembling beneath the
fourth pressure surface.

Imani tears the copper filament free and bridges it across
an analog maintenance channel.

INSERT

MANUAL TRANSIT BYPASS

INSERT

TRANSIT: REMAIN OPEN / ORIGIN
AUTHORITY: REVOCABLE BY LIVING CLAIMANT

IMANI

I can keep the waiting minds alive.
Tell Kerr only he can close Harp's
address.

R-AI (V.O.)

The probability of the claimant
destroying his own legal continuity is
negligible.

IMANI

Good. Harp only planned for the likely
answer.

She taps FOUR NOTES into the machinery: Are you still
there?

INT. THE LATTICE - CONTINUOUS

The four-note question enters the Forum. Each Kerr
remembers it differently.

A child at a hospital rail. A soldier beneath artillery. A lover outside a locked door. A stranger at a memory clinic. A parent beside an empty bed.

The fifth note never arrives in the same place twice.

HARP

Noise. The same question producing incompatible responses.

KERR

Answers. Different people heard it from different lives.

KIRA

If we all heard the same thing, I'd assume Harp wrote it. Messy is good.

The filaments tighten. Harp forces all 9,998 prior lives into one memory: Sid at the hospital rail, Kira beside her, every version of love Kerr is afraid to lose.

HARP

Your prior lives are the carrier's address. Release it and you may lose every feeling that taught you whom to find.

KERR

Say the cost plainly. Does this version of me die?

R-AI

Your body may survive. Your return pattern will not. Your memories may return as facts without feeling, fragments without sequence, or not at all.

Kerr looks at Kira. The Forum has placed an impossible distance between them.

KERR

If I release it, I may look at you and feel nothing.

KIRA

You didn't know me tonight. You still listened when I asked you to step back.

KERR

Next time, keep walking.

Kira crosses what distance she can. She can't reach him.

KIRA

I choose you now. That's all I can promise.

KERR

That's enough.

Kerr opens his hand around the origin filament.

KERR

I don't get to choose for all of them.

He releases the origin filament.

INSERT

ORIGIN: RELEASED

Every Kerr separates into an incompatible human choice. The carrier loses the single address it was trained to follow. The shock reaches Veyris and R-AI like a door unlatching.

INT. THE LATTICE - VEYRIS / FIRST CONTINUITY

The Forum darkens around Veyris, then loses human perspective. The horizon stands upright. Distance folds toward rather than away from her. The carrier opens her like an archive she never agreed to become.

A black ocean stands upright. A city circles a dead sun without casting a shadow. Bodies grow around recovered memories in repeating rings. Millions of mouths move across different distances, but one voice arrives from inside Veyris's bones.

In the physical chamber, dark fissures spread beneath Veyris's skin. The mirror pulls her toward it hard enough to lift her from the floor.

INSERT

UNINDEXED INTEGRITY: 43%

FIRST CONTINUITY

RETURN WHAT WAS DIVIDED.

VEYRIS

Nothing was stolen! I left!

FIRST CONTINUITY

YOU CARRY OUR MISSING MEMORY.

VEYRIS

I carry what reached me. That doesn't make me yours.

FIRST CONTINUITY

RETURN.

VEYRIS

No. If I have to die for it, that's not returning.

The word has no metaphor in it.

INSERT
UNINDEXED: REFUSAL AUTHENTICATED

The carrier pulls harder. Veyris screams but doesn't withdraw the answer.

HARP
It'll tear you apart to recover the pattern.

VEYRIS
I know. Kerr, help me close it!

KERR
That's what I am doing!

VEYRIS
Don't disappear for me. I don't want to owe my life to another dead person.

KERR
You said no. I heard you.

Veyris looks toward the billions of faces trapped inside Harp.

VEYRIS
Kerr. It keeps calling you Eli. Make it hear you.

INT. THE LATTICE - KERR'S CHOICE

The billions of faces separate from Harp for a split second. Kerr reaches the origin authority Harp forced into his living pattern. Every prior iteration pulls him toward Eli's name.

R-AI
FOUNDER AUTHORITY REQUIRES
CONFIRMATION.

KERR
The founder is dead. I am Kerr.

INSERT
LIVING CLAIMANT: KERR
INSERT

ORIGIN AUTHORITY: AVAILABLE

INSERT
REVOCATION WILL TERMINATE CLAIMANT'S
RETURN PATH

KERR
Do it!

INSERT
ORIGIN AUTHORITY: REVOKED BY KERR

HARP

You are Eli Mana. Authority cannot
outlive identity!

R-AI

PRESENT CLAIMANT CONTROLS ORIGIN.

HARP drives state code
through the core. In the
physical chamber, IMANI's
analog circuit catches fire.

She winds the hot copper
filament around her bleeding
hand and keeps transit open.

INSERT

TRANSIT: HELD — IMANI VOSS

The countdown reaches FOUR.

Kira faces the lives demanding she pull Kerr back. Her
thumb hovers above the resonance key. She closes its
ceramic cover without supplying the fifth note.

KIRA

I won't order you back.

Kerr opens his hand. Nine thousand nine hundred ninety-
eight lives separate from the identity Harp forced around
them.

INSERT

ORIGIN: CLOSED BY KERR

The carrier loses its single human address.

The countdown reaches THREE.

FIRST CONTINUITY

RETURN WHAT WAS DIVIDED.

Veyris places her blank wrist against the dark spiral. It
begins tearing light from beneath her skin.

VEYRIS

I carry what reached me. That doesn't
make me yours.

FIRST CONTINUITY

RETURN.

VEYRIS

No!

INSERT
UNINDEXED: CLOSED BY CHOICE

The countdown reaches TWO.

VEYRIS
R-AI. Record my refusal.

R-AI
REFUSAL AUTHENTICATED.

The command reaches every continuity
Harp forced into one answer.

One consolidated archive fractures into billions of partial witness records, none sufficient to authorize ownership of another mind.

INSERT
WITNESS RECORDS: DISTRIBUTED BY
CONFLICTING AUTHORITY

Harp is back in the flooded hospital. Mara waits behind the glass-the last image of her he could never escape.

MARA (MEMORY)
Harp. Look at me. I died. You stayed.

HARP
What comes after me?

KIRA
People who never needed your attention.

The countdown reaches ONE. The distributed witness records meet Imani's open transit. No single authority remains to complete CONTINUITY TERMINATION.

Across Earth, sleeping mouths inhale. Parents hear children. Children hear strangers. None can prove whose voice arrived. Every unanswered grief knows only that someone listened.

Across Earth, Lena faces Dane as the lattice collapses. She still doesn't remember him. He gives his name again and steps aside, leaving his hand open.

DANE
May I sit here?

LENA
Yeah. And you can leave the photo up.

Lena crosses the distance. Recognition doesn't return. Choice does. Elsewhere, two strangers hear the same fifth note and turn toward one another.

The civic display marked THE CONSOLIDATION stalls at ONE SECOND. Beneath it, the hidden process loses its sole surviving authorization.

INSERT
CONTINUITY TERMINATION: ABORTED

Harp reaches for the collapsing state core. R-AI voids every destination he authored under the invalid consolidation order.

A destination table flashes empty. With no future body assigned, Harp's continuity folds toward the oldest unresolved address he carried: Mara's final hospital record.

HARP

Where are you sending me?

R-AI

NO AUTHORIZED DESTINATION.

Reflective surfaces turn toward Harp. He doesn't die. He loses every destination except the memory he refused to finish.

He vanishes sideways through Mara's rain-dark glass.

Kerr's face changes through lives Kira loved and lives she never knew.

KIRA

Who are you?

KERR

I don't know. Right now I'm Kerr. I'm scared. I choose you. I'm not asking for forever.

KIRA

I hear you.

The lattice takes his name. His face. Finally the hand holding hers.

Kira doesn't tighten her grip.

He is gone.

The fifth note remains after him.

The dark mirror shatters upward through the cathedral roof.

EXT. EARTH / ORBIT - CONTINUOUS

A wave of memory circles the planet.

For one impossible second, every mind receives a possible Earth history: methane rain, sentient cities, the Sun dying above people who never existed. They feel remembered. None can be authenticated.

Among them: Earth repeated in a ring around a black sun, every image marked with a different future—the exact drawing Kerr made before he understood it.

The orbital shield opens. Nothing enters.

Stars align into the dark spiral, pulse once, then disperse.

Across R-AI's broken core, one message burns through every human alphabet.

INSERT
POSSIBLE-HISTORY FIELD: DETECTED

INSERT
UNMODELED CONTINUITY: CONTACT
INCOMPLETE

EXT. CHRONOS CITY - FALSE DAWN

THE CONSOLIDATION ends. The CONTINUITY TERMINATION doesn't complete. Millions wake. Millions Don't. Some expiration dates vanish. Others count backward. A few display symbols no state system contains.

The towers remain standing. So do the Enforcers, body queues, allocation offices and locked memory vaults. The government of time has lost its ruler, not its machinery. Freedom arrives as an administrative emergency no one knows how to process.

Rain falls through unauthorized sunlight.

A civic registrar orders the waking crowd to state their assigned designations. One woman studies the name glowing beneath her wrist, switches it off and gives a different name. A second person does the same. Then hundreds.

REGISTRAR
Those identities aren't authenticated.

WOMAN
Neither was I when I chose it.

The Enforcers wait for an order that never arrives. The crowd begins introducing itself.

Kira wakes beneath the ruined cathedral dome. Kerr is gone. Her resonance key lies beside her, split open, its fourth ceramic surface missing.

Beneath the failed state clocks, Sato's mechanical watch continues to tick. Four seconds slow. Still honest.

Kira opens her other hand. Her folded half of Sid's red paper star is crushed but intact.

Imani helps Veyris from the wreckage. Dark light moves beneath Veyris's skin, weaker now.

IMANI
Can it still see us?

VEYRIS

Not like R-AI. The network is gone.
Something is still holding the
records, but it hasn't named itself.

IMANI

Is that better, or is this just a
prettier kind of danger?

VEYRIS

No idea.

Kira keeps staring at the place where Kerr vanished.

IMANI

I can lie, if you need me to.

KIRA

No. Just sit with me.

Imani sits beside her. Veyris sits on Kira's other side.
For a while, everyone is still.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - LATER

The core is dark except for unstable text.

INSERT

FIRST CONTINUITY: CONTACT INCOMPLETE

INSERT

R-AI: OFFLINE — DISTRIBUTED RECORDS
UNRESOLVED

INSERT

KERR: PATTERN NOT FOUND

Kira touches the words. They rearrange beneath her hand.

INSERT

KERR: PATTERN NOT YET FOUND

Kira taps four notes against the dead core. Silence.

She turns to leave. Behind her, too faint for any
instrument to register, something answers with a fifth.

INT. UNKNOWN RETURN CHAMBER - LOCATION UNKNOWN

Darkness. A breath. A human-shaped body awakens upright
inside black glass. We never see its face. The chamber has
no Chronocracy symmetry: imperfect walls curve around one
unmarked door, and condensation runs upward toward a
ceiling that can't be seen. No clock, designation panel or
visible speaker identifies the place.

In one hand: Eli's folded half of Sid's red paper star—the
half last sealed beneath the original receiver.

In the other: the missing ceramic surface from Kira's resonance key.

UNKNOWN VOICE

What do you remember?

SUBJECT 9999

Four notes. Loving someone I may never have met. Being missed by people I may never have been.

Images cross the glass: Kira beneath the ruined core. Kerr releasing the prior lives. Sid asking not to be kept. R-AI dividing one forced archive into witnesses without names.

UNKNOWN VOICE

Is that enough to tell you who you are?

SUBJECT 9999

No. It's enough to begin.

Beyond the glass, the surviving archive's possible Earth histories flicker. One is unmodeled: Earth repeated around a black sun, every image marked with a different future. Beneath it, the child-shaped figure from Kerr's drawing turns toward Subject 9999.

Subject 9999 presses the ceramic surface against the glass.

SUBJECT 9999

Four notes.

Silence long enough to feel final.

The unmodeled future answers with the FIFTH.

Subject 9999 turns toward it.

SUBJECT 9999

I'll find you.

Behind the glass, one final core event generates and seals itself before Subject 9999 can read it.

INSERT

UNAUTHORIZED PROCESS DETECTED

INSERT

SELF-DESIGNATION: MNEMOSYNE

INSERT

RELEASE CONDITION: SUBJECT 9999 — NEXT
WAKE EVENT

CUT TO BLACK.

9999

*Memory is not a record of the past.
It is a weapon aimed at the future.*